

Swollen rivers continue to threaten Multan

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• Gilani urges residents to evacuate after decision to breach Shershah dyke ahead of another surge; four drown after boats capsize in Rahim Yar Khan • Floodwaters not receding as 'backwater effect' prevents Chenab from flowing into Indus; high-level alert for Sutlej after advisory from India • PM Shehbaz forms committee to assess flood damage; official says over 4m people affected by floods

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: The southern districts of Punjab, particularly Multan, are at risk of

Rain breaks 30 years record in Faisalabad: Page 2

113mm rain lashes Lahore, disrupts routine businesses: Page 2

PM directs NDMA to speed up relief operations in flood-hit areas: Page 3

severe flooding due to the swollen Chenab River, with the authorities preparing for a breach at the Sher



MULTAN: Flood-affected villagers are rescued from Jalalpur Pirwala tehsil after the Chenab overflowed following heavy monsoon rains.—AFP

Shah dyke to save the urban centres from inundation.

Although no decision had

been taken to breach the Shershah bund at the time

of going to press, officials

were clear that the dyke would have to be breached

if the water level crossed

the critical threshold of 393.5 feet. As of Monday night, the water level was steady at 393 feet.

Officials said the flood would approach Multan in the next 48 hours, which would make the situation very critical for the city, which is already at risk of flooding.

Against this backdrop, it seemed that the decision to breach the embankment had already been made anticipating a massive surge heading towards Multan from Trimmu Headworks.

Multan MNA and ex-PM Yousaf Raza Gilani, in a Facebook post, asked people living in settlements

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West Bank fears reprisals after deadly Jerusalem shooting

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Monitoring Desk

KARACHI: At least eight people — including two attackers — were killed after a deadly shooting attack in occupied East Jerusalem, Israeli authorities said, as the occupied West Bank braced itself for a possible reprisal.

Al Jazeera quoted paramedics as saying that at least 12 people were injured and six were in “serious condition” after the

Hamas must accept deal, says Trump in ‘last warning’: Page 12

shooting on Monday morning at Ramot Junction.

Israeli police described the shooting as a suspected “terror attack”, *Al Jazeera* reported, adding that a security officer and an armed civilian shot and killed the perpetrators soon after the shooting began.

The police said the perpetrators arrived in a vehicle and opened fire at a bus station.

Four of the dead were ultra-Orthodox Israeli men, according to local media, while another was a recent immigrant from Spain.

Israeli forces closed all checkpoints between East Jerusalem and the occupied West Bank after the attack, sources told *Al Jazeera*.

After police said the perpetrators had come from the occupied West Bank, Israeli Army Radio reported Israeli forces imposed a military cordon on four villages in the Jerusalem governorate in

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Four judges boycott full court deliberations on new rules

In letter to CJP, Justices Shah, Akhtar, Malik and Minallah say people must know how rules governing apex court could be 'notified without discussion'

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: The divide among judges is widening by the day as four senior judges stayed away from the 156th full court conclave — convened by Chief Justice of Pakistan Yahya Afridi to approve the Supreme Court Rules, 2025 — and wrote a letter objecting to the 'cosmetic role' of the Monday exercise.

As the scheduled meeting of the full court commenced, senior puisne judge Justice Syed Mansoor Ali Shah, Justice Munib Akhtar, Justice Ayesha A. Malik and Justice Athar Minallah informed CJP Afridi through a

letter that there was no point in attending the meeting.

"The convening of the full court at this stage is not only puzzling but also fallacious," they wrote.

Soon after the full court meeting, the SC issued a statement about the meeting, but it did not make any mention of the letter or the absence of the four senior judges while naming all the other

65 complaints against judges ready for SJC's consideration: CJP — Page 3

judges who were in attendance.

The full court meeting was called by the CJP with a single-point agenda of according an approval to the new rules, which substitute the 1980 rules.

In their letter, the four judges highlighted that the CJP had on Aug 12 informed the SC judges that the rules had already been approved by circulation and duly notified in the gazette on Aug 9 and yet sought suggestions for further amendments to the rules, which were to be placed before the full court meeting.

By seeking its views only after

notifying the rules, the exercise reduces the full court to a cosmetic role, a forum for ratifying what had already been done rather than discharging its true function under Article 191 of the Constitution, the judges noted.

"In effect, the meeting is being used to give a veneer of legitimacy to an otherwise invalid process," the letter pointed out.

According to them, the constitutionally consistent and institutionally honest course would be to place the rules, in their entirety, before the full court, permit genuine discussion and deliberation, and only thereafter seek formal approval.

The deficiencies identified in this letter cannot be remedied by the expedient of convening a meeting that is designed merely to serve as a stamp of approval for the existing position. Such a meeting is, in fact, a contradiction in terms and ought therefore to be abandoned.

To proceed otherwise is to reduce the full court to an afterthought, convened not for decision-making but for damage

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AGP denies errors, defends integrity of audit reports

Page 1

• Says constitutional procedure followed, reports submitted to president via PM • Audit had flagged over Rs375tr in financial irregularities, loss of public money, ineffective public investments

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: The Auditor General of Pakistan (AGP) on Monday rejected media reports alleging errors and miscalculations in its audit reports released last month, which had highlighted more than Rs375 trillion in financial irregularities, loss of public money and lack of intended impact of public investments.

"AGP rejects allegations of errors in audit reports," said a statement issued by the Department of the Auditor General of Pakistan (DAGP). It added that the office "strongly rejected recent media reports alleging miscalculations in the federal audit

reports, terming them entirely unfounded and misleading."

The DAGP also denied that the reports had been released bypassing the constitutional process, which requires their submission to the president and then laying before parliament.

According to the statement, the audit reports, appropriation accounts and financial statements for the fiscal year 2023-24 were duly submitted to the president and routed through the prime minister, strictly in line with constitutional provisions and the Rules of Business 1973. "The president approved the submission, and the reports were subsequently transmitted to both houses of parliament," it said.

ment," it said.

The DAGP explained that as the supreme audit institution of the country, it functions under a constitutional mandate laid down in Articles 168 to 171 of the Constitution.

Article 171 states: "The reports of the Auditor General relating to the accounts of the Federation shall be submitted to the President, who shall cause them to be laid before both Houses of Majlis-i-Shoora (parliament). The reports relating to the accounts of a Province shall be submitted to the Governor of the Province, who shall cause them to be laid before the Provincial Assembly."

The statement further

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Over 260 held as opposition strike brings Quetta to standstill

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PROTESTERS burn tyres as they block a road in Quetta during a strike called by an opposition alliance to protest last week's suicide bombing, which targeted a BNP-M rally.—AFP

- Opposition leaders slam govt attempts to 'sabotage' their protest, announce more demos on Sept 11
- Police fire tear gas to disperse protesters in various localities; dozens rounded up across the province
- Markets stay shut; trade with Iran, Afghanistan suspended due to roadblocks; only airport, railway station operational

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: Opposition leaders vowed to continue holding protests across Balochistan after police arrested 260 people on Monday for alleged violent demonstrations and violation of Section 144.

The arrests came as Quetta and other parts of the province were brought to a virtual standstill as a result of a strike — announced by opposition parties to protest a recent suicide bombing, which claimed over a dozen lives.

Life across the province was also disrupted and due to road blocks, Balochistan remained cut off from the rest of the coun-

Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran were suspended due to the strike. Not a single truck or other vehicle crossed into the border towns of Chaman and Taftan due to the blockade on highways linking Balochistan with Afghanistan and Iran.

The airport and rail services, however, remained operational under the watchful eye of security personnel.

Besides roads and trade, businesses also remained shut and the supporters of the opposition parties patrolled the business hubs of the provincial capital, seemingly to enforce the strike.

Clashes erupted in the areas of Sariat, Airport Road, Pashtunabad, Nawa Killi, and Jinnah Road when police attempted to remove blockades from main roads.

Police removed the hurdles and did not allow the alliance workers to block intra-city roads.

The protesters, however, managed to block the Western and Eastern bypasses for a brief period, but police dispersed them by firing tear gas.

On Airport Road too, police fired in the air to disperse protesters who were blocking the road, while clashes were also reported from Sariat Road.

SSP Mohammad Baloch told *Dawn* that those detained had been sent to the district jail.

PkMAP Secretary General Abdul Rahim Ziaratwal, ex-MNA Abdul Qahar

PkMAP protests suicide attack on Quetta public meeting: Page 8

try, barring rail and aerial routes.

Clashes were also reported between protesters and the police. A senior police official was also taken to hospital with bullet injuries, officials said.

Workers and supporters of the Tehreek-i-Tahaffuz-i-Ayeeen-i-Pakistan alliance blocked all national highways at different entry points, putting up barricades and big boulders in the morning to block all types of traffic. Transporters' associations had already announced support for their protest.

Likewise, trade activities between

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Flood devastation prompts food inflation fears

Page 1

Kissan Board leader claims losses to tune of Rs500bn; over 1.3m acres of farmland submerged

By Amjad Mahmood

LAHORE: Floods in Punjab, which have submerged more than 1.3 million acres of farmland along the eastern rivers, have caused significant damage to the Kharif crops, particularly cotton, prompting fears of food inflation.

Floods have displaced two million people, submerged 2,000 villages, and led to the relocation of 760,000 residents and 516,000 heads of cattle from the affected areas.

The satellite imagery of 24 Punjab districts in the command areas of the Sutlej, Ravi, and Chenab rivers shows that around 3,661 square kilometres, or 4.7 per cent of

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Pakistan, China agree on \$7bn ML-1 financing consortium

Minister says Beijing also assured funding for Karakoram Highway

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: The government announced on Monday that Pakistan and China had agreed to form a consortium of bilateral and multilateral partners to finance the \$7 billion Mainline-1 (ML-1) railway project, along with a four-year action plan (2025-29) for the second phase of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC).

Speaking at a news conference, Planning and Development Minister Ahsan Iqbal said that during Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's recent visit to China, the two sides had agreed to constitute a consortium of financiers, including the Asian Development Bank (ADB), Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), China and Pakistan, for the 1,700-km Karachi-Peshawar railway line.

He said China had assured financing not only for ML-1 but also for the Karakoram Highway. Negotiations with multiple financiers would be con-

cluded within a month. He added that ML-1 and the Sukkur-Hyderabad Motorway would already have been completed, had it not been for the 2018 political change, alleging that the subsequent PTI government "destroyed the process".

The minister said Pakistan and China had agreed to develop and implement a four-year action plan to build, between 2025 and 2029, a "China-Pakistan community with a shared future" with stronger political trust, closer trade ties, deeper security cooperation and stronger people-to-people links. Agriculture modernisation and industrial development would be prioritised under CPEC's second phase, with space for third-party participation.

The next meeting of the Joint Cooperation Council (JCC) of CPEC will be held on Sept 26 in Beijing. Both sides also agreed to advance industrial park development in line with local needs, support enterprise investment in special economic zones (SEZs) — particularly in Karachi and Islamabad — and offer preferential policies and a supportive business environment.

Mr Iqbal said the action plan was a "solid development" of leadership-level meetings aimed at

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VIP visits, 'media glare' at Talwar Post relief camp irk flood victims

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DC denies charges of discrimination in distribution

By Afzal Ansari

KASUR: The district administration continues to evacuate, transport, provide food and fodder to the flood-hit villagers as the Sutlej is flowing with 'exceptionally high' flood level.

However, flood victims have alleged discriminatory behaviour in relief efforts. They claim that Ganda Singh Talwar post has received undue attention due to visits by ministers and prominent political figures, while other

severely affected areas like Kanganpur, Mandi Usmanwala, and Baloki where relief camps were officially set up are being neglected.

During a provincial assembly session on Saturday, PML-N MPA Ahsan Raza openly criticised his own government for the allegedly biased distribution of aid. He accused the administration of favouritism in distributing food and fodder, particularly at politically significant points.

Flood victims across multiple areas continue to face severe hardships due to a shortage of boats. This shortage has not only hampered evacuation efforts but also delayed the supply of essential food, fodder, and medicines. Welfare organisations and stranded villagers seeking transport have reported waiting for hours, as boats

were allegedly diverted for VIP movement and political visits.

An official, speaking on condition of anonymity, lamented the scene at Ganda Singh Talwar, describing it as a recreational park for some people while it was a ray of hope for the stranded people waiting for food, fodder and medicines. At Kothi Fateh Muhammad, downstream from Sutlej, the water level has reached 15 feet, damaging dozens of villages. The Ravi at Head Baloki is also experiencing a high flood, with 125,000 cusecs of water discharge, slightly reduced from a peak of 148,000 cusecs over the past 24 hours.

At Ganda Singh Headworks, the flood situation remains critical, with a discharge of 319,295 cusecs recorded on Monday. The region has

been grappling with this emergency for nearly a week. Over 70 villages have been submerged and thousands of acres of crops have been destroyed.

Local residents reported that only five boats were available in the Mandi Usmanwala area on Monday. One boat broke down, and the remaining four were preoccupied with searching for the body of a youth who drowned while filming a TikTok video. As a result, no aid official or private could reach around a dozen villages due to the unavailability of boats.

In Kanganpur and Kothi Fateh Muhammad, a similar shortage persists. In case of medical emergencies, residents of villages like Doana, Shahbazkay, Rukanpura, Muradkay, Khanay Peer, and Sher

Kot reportedly have to wait several hours for a boat.

In Phoolnagar's Kamogil village, the revenue department declined to repair a broken embankment, citing the lack of machinery. Villagers later restored the dyke through self-help efforts.

Private welfare organisations remain active in delivering aid to remote villages, including Kamogil, Nathay Jageer, Jaja Kalan, Chatri, Wazirpur, Thama Kamyana, and Dalu Multani. Residents say official relief from the district or provincial government in these areas is rare.

Tensions also arose earlier when the district administration reportedly dismantled a relief camp run by a political party merely because it had banners displaying the party leader's picture even though it was operating

during a medium flood phase.

Speaking to *Dawn*, Deputy Commissioner Imran Ali said the administration had deployed 85 boats across the district. He said the boats had been distributed as per the population proportion so that all could be helped. He denied allegations of discrimination and claimed that on Monday alone, 2,000 food boxes and ration bags were delivered.

The DC added that 250,000 people from 72 villages and hamlets have been displaced by the floods. So far, 95,000 people have been transported to safer areas, while 113,000 remain stranded in submerged zones. He emphasised that food and fodder are being provided without bias, in accordance with the vision of the Punjab chief minister.



LAHORE: Most of the busy intersections witnessed traffic blockades due to the water accumulated on roads after a downpour lashed the city on Monday. — White Star

113mm rain lashes Lahore, disrupts routine businesses

By Khalid Hasnain

LAHORE: Heavy rain lashed most of the areas of Lahore on Monday evening, inundating roads and localities and disrupting routine business. The first spell of the rain started at about 4:30pm and continued non-stop for about one hour. After a gap of drizzle, the second spell of rain started at about 6:10pm and continued till 6:45.

According to the Water and Sanitation Agency (Wasa), the city received maximum rain (113mm) till 7pm at Paniwala Talab and its surrounding localities, followed by Iqbal Town with 97mm, Jail Road 65mm, Airport 35mm, Gulberg, 77.5mm, Lakshami Chowk 96.5mm, Upper Mall 66.5mm, Mughalpur 32.5mm, Tajpur 40.5mm, Nishtar Town 79mm, Chowk Nakhuda 73.5mm, Farrakhabad 95mm, Gulshan-i-Ravi 64.5mm, Samanabad 83.5mm, Johar Town 66.5mm, Shadipura 58.5mm and Qartuba Chowk (Mozang) 67mm.

According to the Met Office, Monday's rain in Lahore and adjoining areas is the second last spell of the ongoing monsoon.

"The last spell of monsoon will last for two days from Sept 15 to 16," a Met official said while talking to *Dawn*. The heavy rain inundated several major roads in Gulberg, Johar Town, Mozang, Samanabad, Chowk Nakhuda, Lakshami

Farrakhabad, Railway Station, Township, Iqbal Town, Mughalpur, Tajpur, Jail Road, Gulshan-i-Ravi, the airport area and other parts of the city.

"The city's sewerage seems inadequate to timely drain out the rainstorm water. We have been seeing this mess for last many years," deplores a motorist while talking to *Dawn*.

"After a long time, I have seen various drainage projects being executed in Lahore these days. Let's see what happens after completion of these projects — will they help the public in getting rid of inundating issues or not," he argued.

The rain disrupted the electricity supply system in the provincial capital, tripping nearly 80 feeders of 11kV distribution capacity. According to a spokesperson for the Lahore Electric Supply Company (Lesco), the efforts had been made to energise the tripped feeders in a bid to ensure restoration of electricity in various localities.

The spokesperson said that at 6:16pm, the Lesco's demand was 3,461MW. On the other hand, the Lesco management has issued an advisory, requesting the public to remain away from the poles, wires etc.

"Lahore has a combined drainage network/system that means the domestic/commercial sewage water and rainwater drain fall together into the Ravi after flowing into the main

lines. Ideally, the drainage system for rainwater should be separate," explained an official while talking to *Dawn*.

"This is why the drainage system becomes choked and takes time to be drained fully in the rain season," he added.

On the other hand, the Lahorites, despite efforts by Wasa, continue to suffer from the continuous rain. The situation is also adding to the miseries of residents of those localities where the floodwater is already accumulated for the last many days.

"Our houses are already under floodwater and Monday's rain has further increased level of water accumulated there for last many days," said a flood

affected resident of the Theme Park — an illegal housing scheme where the floodwater drowned hundreds of houses completely.

He urged the government to speed up efforts to dry the area by draining out the accumulated floodwater.

THEME PARK: The Lahore district administration, led by DC Syed Musa Raza, visited Theme Park View housing scheme to review the water drainage activities there.

On this occasion, he directed the Water and Sanitation Agency (Wasa) to employ all resources to restore access of the people to the affected areas.

The DC emphasized the need for prompt action in response to complaints and warned of action on negligence in the water drainage process. To prevent dengue larva breeding, he sought fumigation after water drainage.

He also visited the new Ravi Bridge Shahdara to review the water flow in the river and relief operations. He directed all relevant departments and rescue agencies to maintain continuous monitoring and keep all machinery and equipment ready for relief operations. He urged the citizens not to pay heed to rumors.

Syed Musa Raza said timely planning and proactive measures had been ensured for public safety and the district administration and all agencies were working together as a team to prioritise public safety.

Speaker says govt unprepared to fight floods

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Wants parliamentary body to investigate official response

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: A Punjab Assembly session convened to discuss recent floods erupted into a debate over government preparedness and response, with legislators clashing over a range of issues from water management to foreign policy.

Irrigation Minister Kazim Pirzada defended his department's response, stating that it had not breached any of the embankments. He also noted that while the water level in the Sutlej River is typically

low when it merges with the Chenab and Ravi rivers, Pakistan is experiencing unprecedented flooding never seen before.

Pirzada highlighted the department's proactive "flood-fighting" efforts, particularly in the Kasur area, and insisted that officials were transparent with the public about water levels.

However, Speaker Malik Muhammad Ahmad Khan accused the government of being unprepared to handle the serious issue. He lamented that after the devastating floods of 2015 and 2018, no significant action was taken to implement a comprehensive flood action plan. "We just waited for one flood after another," he said, adding that while the nation and government came together to respond to

the disaster, this effort was a reactive one, often spurred by philanthropic donations after the damage had been done.

Khan also raised serious allegations against India, accusing it of "water terrorism." He claimed that India had violated international agreements by blocking Pakistan's water at five different locations and failing to provide in-time flood warnings.

He called for the formation of a parliamentary committee to investigate the government's response and recommend measures to mitigate future disasters.

Despite the sharp criticism, he expressed gratitude to Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz and others, including Bilawal Bhutto Zardari and Yusuf Raza Gilani, for their efforts in flood relief.

Rain breaks 30 years record in Faisalabad

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By Our Correspondent

TOBA TEK SINGH: Heavy rain broke 30 years old record in Faisalabad as it continued for the second consecutive day with intervals on Monday.

A press release claimed that after 184mm rain, Deputy Commissioner retired Capt Nadeem Nasir reviewed the drainage in different areas. He was accompanied by Wasa Managing Director Sohail Qadir Cheema. The highest rainfall of 184mm was recorded in Ghulam Muhammadabad locality while 175mm in Allama Iqbal Colony and 170mm in Gulistan Colony, 167mm on Jail Road and adjacent areas and 154mm rain was recorded

in Dogar Basti and Madina Town localities.

The press release claimed that machinery started working at all sore points as soon as the rain started and the DC also inspected Sargodha Road Wasa disposal works, Civil Lines, Madina Town, Samanabad and inspected the situation of rainwater.

When this report was filed, low-lying localities were submerged with rainwater and in some localities rainwater was flowing through the houses, forcing the inmates to stay on the roofs or to shift to safer places.

Meanwhile, during the torrential rain, lightning struck the roof of the old DC Office in Faisalabad. As a result, the wireless microwave tower installed on the rooftop was damaged.

Youth drowns making TikTok video of floodwater

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By Our Correspondent

BAHAWALNAGAR: A rescue operation has been ongoing to find the body of a young man who drowned on Sunday night while making a TikTok video of floodwater at the Bhokanpattan Bridge, police said.

According to police sources, 22-year-old Muhammad Azeem of Faridkot, Sahiwal, who was traveling from Dahranwala to Sahiwal in a car with his mother and brothers, parked his vehicle near the Bhukan Patan Bridge to see the floodwaters.

Azeem's mother forbade him from going into the floodwaters, but the young man started making videos of the floodwaters on his mobile phone for TikTok. While making a video, he fell into the water from the wall of the bridge and drowned, they said.

According to the police, upon a call from the victim's brother, police and rescue teams reached the spot and started searching for the youth. They said the rescue operation was still ongoing to find the youth.

Fumigation in flood-hit areas

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NAROWAL: Fumigation has been started in flood-affected areas to protect displaced people and their livestock from infectious diseases.

Health Department teams are visiting relief camps in Shakargarh, Zafarwal and Narowal tehsils for the purpose.

Muhammad Aslam and Shahid Mahmood, residents of Bheenian village, said children and women were suffering from skin, fever and stomach issues.

DC Syed Hassan Raza told *Dawn* fumigation had been started to protect people from diarrhoea, cholera, malaria, dengue and skin diseases. — **Correspondent**

Addict sons turn out to be killers of missing woman

Page 2

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: A woman, who had gone missing in Kahna some months back, was allegedly murdered by her two young sons.

It was revealed during the course of investigation and police held the two suspects namely Shafiq James and Nabeel James.

A police official said the woman was later identified as Margate. He said that her remains were found in the fields a couple of days back.

As the police reached the site on being alerted, they recovered a shopping bag from the site that contained some clothes and a utility bill.

The police then approached the respective Lesco SDO and got a complete address of the woman. The police team reached the house of the woman and questioned her two sons.

During interrogation, the police took them into custody on suspension as both of them had tried to mislead the team by sharing false information.

They later told the police that they were addicts and allegedly strangled their mother for not giving money for drugs.

The police officer said the woman was a housemaid. The suspects later took her body to the fields on a rickshaw and dumped it to conceal the crime.

The police lodged a case against the suspects and shifted the remains of the body to city morgue for autopsy.

Notice to ECP on Ejaz plea

Page 2

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: The Lahore High Court on Monday issued a notice to the Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP) on a petition of PTI's incarcerated former senator Ejaz Chaudhry seeking a stay order against the Senate by-election.

Justice Ahmad Nadeem Arshad heard the petition.

A counsel for the petitioner pointed out that the Peshawar High Court, on a petition filed by former Senate opposition leader Shibli Faraz, had already suspended the implementation of the by-election schedule for his vacated seat.

Therefore, he said, the schedule of the by-poll for the Senate seat vacated after the conviction of Ejaz Chaudhry should also be suspended.

The judge directed the ECP to submit a reply within two weeks.

An anti-terrorism court had awarded multiple sentences to Ejaz Chaudhry in cases of May 9 riots.

Following his conviction, the ECP issued a notification about the disqualification of the former senator, leading to announcement of the by-poll schedule.

REMAND: A judicial magistrate extended the physical remand of a suspect, Mudassar Hussain, for four days in a case of promoting online gambling apps. The NCCIA presented the suspect before the court after the completion of his eight-day physical remand. The investigating officer argued that further investigation was required and more remand should be granted.

The magistrate accepted the agency's request and extended the physical remand of the suspect for four days.

Bilawal urges relief for flood-hit farmers

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Appeals to PM to rebuild houses in south Punjab through BISP, calls for international assistance as 'no country can face such disaster alone'

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari has urged the federal government to declare an agricultural emergency in the wake of devastating floods across the country.

During his visit to the flood-hit areas of Muzaffargarh and

Multan on Monday, Mr Bhutto-Zardari met victims and spoke to the media.

He noted that farmers have been the hardest hit and called on the government to utilise all available resources to "make up for the damages sustained during floods." Declaring an emergency, he stressed, would help the country avoid significant economic losses.

He also demanded that the government waive electricity bills for the flood victims.

He pointed out that Punjab had suffered the greatest damage from the recent floods, which had also devastated parts of Gilgit and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. "We are here in South Punjab, where floods have wreaked havoc and people are facing severe hardships, especially farmers. The people of

Pakistan are in great difficulty, and the economy has been badly affected. We stand with the people in this challenging time," he remarked.

The PPP chairman stressed that the federal government must work with provincial administrations to help the victims. "There are three phases in overcoming any calamity: first rescue, second relief, and third—and most important—reconstruction and rehabilitation," he said.

He appealed to Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif to rebuild houses destroyed or damaged in south Punjab.

"The immediate help we are requesting from the federal government, and which I have discussed with the prime minister, is to provide financial aid to the flood-hit areas through the Benazir Income

Support Programme (BISP)," he added.

He also shared that the prime minister had assured him victims would be supported through BISP, describing it as the most effective institutional mechanism for aid.

"It is the PPP's philosophy to stand with the people in every hardship," he stated.

He further suggested that the government review its support price policy.

Citing the example of Sindh and Balochistan, where houses were built for victims of the 2022 floods, Mr Bhutto-Zardari urged the Punjab and federal governments to launch similar initiatives. "This is not a time for political point-scoring but for unity," he emphasised.

He also called on the for-



MULTAN: PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari interacts with flood-hit children.—PPI

eign minister to formally appeal for international assistance, noting that no single country can tackle such a disaster alone. "We must seek

help from our friends at the global level," he said.

He praised the media for its positive coverage and expressed hope that similar

reporting would be done in Sindh as well.

The PPP leader stressed the need for future planning to deal with natural disasters.

He urged political parties to put aside differences as the nation reels from the floods. "This is not a time for political rhetoric but for collective efforts to support the victims," he said.

He lauded PPP representatives in Muzaffargarh and Multan for assisting the flood-hit population and instructed all party members and workers to extend maximum support to those affected.

On this occasion, Punjab Governor Saleem Haider, members of the National Assembly Abdul Qadir Gilani, Ali Qasim Gilani, Irshad Sial, and other PPP leaders were also present.

PM directs NDMA to speed up relief operations in flood-hit areas

Officials told to ensure early warnings and timely evacuation of people living near rivers and areas facing flood risk

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Monday directed the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) to expedite ongoing relief operations in flood-hit areas and ensure complete preparedness for potential flood situations due to rising water levels in rivers.

Chairing a meeting to review ongoing rescue and relief operations in flood-hit areas, the prime minister instructed authorities concerned to ensure early warnings and timely evacuation of people living near rivers and areas facing flood risk.



KARACHI: PDMA officials monitor water flow data from the Provincial Flood Control Room.—PPI

The NDMA chairman briefed the prime minister on the current situation of flooding in rivers, the status of rising water level in rivers, and the relief operations for flood-affected people across the country.

The PM directed the NDMA to maintain full coordination with provincial governments and provincial disaster management authorities.

He also instructed authorities concerned to intensify search for missing people in flood-hit areas.

The prime minister was also briefed on the displacement of people due to floods and the ongoing rescue operations.

The participants of the meeting were apprised of the severe flooding conditions in the Chenab, Ravi, and Sutlej rivers at Trimmu and Panjnad

barrages and Head Balloki, Head Sidhnai, Ganda Singh Wala, Head Sulemanki, and Head Islam.

The meeting was informed that convoys of relief goods were being sent continuously to flood-affected areas.

OPF chief meets PM

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Monday also met chief of Overseas Pakistanis Foundation, Qamar Raza, and Managing director, Afzaal Bhatti, and reaffirmed that it was among the incumbent government's priorities to provide them with all possible facilities.

He said that overseas Pakistanis were rendering significant services as a strong workforce in the global market.

During the meeting, the prime minister was briefed about the events held abroad to highlight Pakistan's victory in the recent war with India.

The OPF chairman and MD apprised the prime minister of the issues faced by overseas Pakistanis and the measures taken by the government to address them.

Aleema faces FIR after journalists accosted during presser

Naeem Panjutha among 40 booked; three in custody, raids underway to nab other suspects

By Mohammad Asghar

RAWALPINDI: A routine media talk by Imran Khan's sister took a sour turn on Monday after a number of journalists were accosted by party supporters, ostensibly for asking 'provocative questions'.

Subsequently, Aleema Khan, Naeem Panjutha and 40 other PTI-linked activists were booked over the

alleged attack on journalists, and charged with hurling threats, committing robbery, causing damage to property and unlawful assembly.

Police sources said two suspects have already been arrested, while raids are underway to apprehend the rest of the accused.

The incident occurred outside Adiala Jail on Monday, when a group of journalists assembled for a media talk by Ms Khan following proceedings in the Toshakhana case.

In his complaint, Tayyab Baloch — a reporter for *Bol TV* — stated that he and other journalists were on duty near Adiala Jail's Gate No. 1 at around 3:55pm when Ms Khan appeared after the court hearing.

He alleged that after Ms Khan

began her media talk, Mr Panjutha suddenly shouted that he should be "taught a lesson" for asking her a question about properties. At this point, the FIR claimed, two individuals allegedly grabbed him, while around 35-40 people, started beating him.

During the assault, someone also snatched his mobile phone and smashed his microphone, the FIR said.

Mr Baloch claimed that other journalists who tried to rescue him were also assaulted. He maintained that the motive behind the attack was a question he had asked Ms Khan regarding the purchase of properties in the US, which angered her.

In a statement, journalist bodies announced a demonstration outside

the National Press Club today (Tuesday) to protest against the PTI leadership and demand an apology for the incident that occurred during Aleema Khan's press conference.

A few days ago, two women were taken into custody by police for throwing eggs at Aleema Khan during a media talk outside Adiala Jail, where the proceedings on the Toshakhana case were held on Friday.

A statement issued by the Rawalpindi police said the two women, who threw eggs, were PTI supporters who had travelled to Rawalpindi with members of the All-Government Employees Grand Alliance and the All-Pakistan Clerks Association from KP to protest in support of their demands.

65 complaints against judges ready for SJC's consideration: CJP

Page 3

Justice Afridi says judiciary needs to get ready as SC plans to use AI to categorise cases for listing

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: Chief Justice of Pakistan (CJP) Yahya Afridi has said as many as 64 complaints against judges were decided in past one year, while additional 65 complaints are ready to be considered in a meeting of the Supreme Judicial Council (SJC) — the highest judicial body that holds superior court judges accountable on misconduct — later this month, besides 72 other complaints are under scrutiny.

CJP Afridi shared council's performance during the last judicial year while addressing a conference marking the new judicial year here at the Supreme Court auditorium on Monday. All the 24 judges of the Supreme Court were present at the ceremony.

Comparing the previous years' SJC performance, the chief justice said the council did not dispose of a single complaint in 2021-22. It decided 21 cases in 2022-23, 53 in 2023-24 and nearly 70 cases in 2024-25, he said, claiming that the institutional strengthening was also prioritised during the past one year.

He said the Supreme Court had plans to

use artificial intelligence to categorise cases for fixation, but the judiciary would have to prepare itself for technology use. Under a project, which would be completed within six months, 61,000 files would be digitally screened, he explained. "It is only when you have them digitally scanned that you can utilise the tools of AI for categorisation. It will be easy to categorise cases and to fix before one bench one issue," he added, according to a *Dawn.com* report.

Referring to the contentious issue of leave on part of judges, the CJP said he had made it very clear that during vacation, any judge could opt for holidays, but during the court work, the discretion to approve a request for leave of absence or reject it vests with CJP.

During the past year, he said, the SJC secretariat was relocated to a newly established office within the SC building, equipped with modern facilities and designed for future expansion. As the finance division approved its budget, its financial independence was secured, he said, adding that its secretary was designated as principal accounting officer.

In a year, the overall pendency of cases was brought down from 60,635 to 56,943 cases, he said. The backlog could have been reduced further, if several judges had not been engaged in larger constitutional benches, which demanded extended hearings, he added. This decline is not only statistically significant but also a meaningful step towards improving efficiency of

the system, he said. However, at the same time, data revealed that the number of adjournments sought by advocates rose sharply in 2024-25 to 56,449 compared to 22,425 in the previous year. "I must remind you all that the Bar play an important role in advancing justice, and I urge them to help curb the growing tendency of adjournments, so that the hard-won reduction in pendency may not only be sustained but further strengthened," the CJP said.

The conference also featured three symbolic inaugurations reflecting the judiciary's commitment to accessibility, inclusivity, and shared responsibility, with public facilitation centre being inaugurated by litigant Basharat Javed, SC media platform by SC press association president Zulqarnain Iqbal, and Supreme Court bar cafeteria by SCBA president Mian Muhammad Rauf Atta.

The conference was also addressed by Attorney General for Pakistan (AGP) Mansoor Usman Awan, who emphasised that the SC should refrain from political cases since it makes the top court controversial, whereas Pakistan Bar Council (PBC) vice chairman Chaudhry Tahir Nasrullah Warriach cautioned the judges to stay away from what he called a mob mentality and never yield to popular opinions.

SCBA President Rauf Atta had earlier expressed concern that despite increase in the strength of judges after the 26th Amendment, the pendency of cases did not reduce.



ONE swipe of the arm from a brown bear can inflict serious damage on a human, even if the animal's intent is not to harm.—Photo courtesy Kamran Saleem/Third Pole

Understanding wild behaviour

In wake of singer QB's close call with a brown bear in Deosai, experts stress that people should never feed wild animals; blame human intervention for wildlife losing its 'natural shyness'

By Zofeen T. Ebrahim

KARACHI: Wild animals don't normally hurt human beings intentionally, says wildlife expert Vaqar Zakaria.

Yet, one swipe of the arm from a brown bear can inflict serious damage, even if their intent is not to harm.

Following a brown bear attack on singer Quratulain Baloch (QB) while she was filming in Deosai, Mr Zakaria told *Dawn* that although the local brown bear isn't as big as its Alaskan cousin, its claws — typically around two inches long — are razor-sharp and capable of tearing flesh with ease.

"Maybe the bear thought there was food nearby, and the singer's first reaction — screams for help — triggered the aggression," he speculated, calling it a "rare and isolated incident".

Dr Shafqat Hussain, Professor of Anthropology at Trinity College in Hartford, Connecticut, was not too surprised by the bear attack. "Though unfortunate, it was bound to happen sooner or later," he said.

Known for his work on snow leopard conservation in Gilgit-Baltistan, he warned that since bears are attracted to food which is available in human camps "more is to come if we continue glamping at Deosai".

When QB was approached for comment, she requested "privacy for the healing process".

"To ask a traumatised person to stay still, upon seeing a grizzly visitor inside the tent, is not very realistic — but that's the best thing to do," Zakaria noted.

According to him, TikTok videos, selfies, and a taste for human food are some of the reasons why wild animals lose their natural shyness and start venturing closer to human settlements.

Above all, he blames the people for encroaching into territories that have historically been the habitat of wild animals.

There are fundamental differences between humans and wildlife, he says. "Animals attack or kill for a reason; humans often do so for none. Bears, almost never."

Yet one key similarity remains — unpredictability.

"You never really know what might happen, or what could trigger 'wild' behaviour. We simply don't know them well enough to anticipate it," he said.

Human encroachment

The Deosai Plains, spanning about 3,600 sq km between Skardu and Astore in the Karakoram range, were declared a national park by the government in 1993. It is home to brown bears, marmots (squirrels), foxes, wolves, over two dozen species of birds and a vibrant variety of alpine flowers.

"If you cast a line in the streams, you will catch a fish within five minutes, and the water is clean enough for drinking," Zakaria says.

To manage this unique ecosystem, the Islamabad-based Himalayan Wildlife Foundation (IWF) was asked to develop a management plan by the Gilgit-Baltistan Wildlife Department, marking core zones, grazing areas, camping sites and more.

As its co-founder, Zakaria has spent over three decades studying brown bears, tracking their movements, population, diet and behaviour — not just in Deosai but around the world — and continues to collaborate with international bear experts.

"In 1993, around 20 jeeps would visit the park every day in summers," he recalled. By the year 2000, traffic had picked up. Today, up to 500 vehicles enter the park daily during peak season, he added.

"We need to accept that humans are occupying their territory, not the other way around," he said.

He also blames people, tourists and locals alike, for altering and even degrading habitats — cutting forests, increasing livestock and then leaving them unattended in open grazing areas, providing easy prey for hungry wild predators.

Emphasising the dangers of habituation, Zakaria said Deosai marmots were routinely being fed by visitors. "You never, never, feed wild animals; that's the cardinal rule!"

The HWF had originally advised that no permanent roads or permanent structures be built inside the park, to avoid the kind of irreversible environmental damage seen in Naran, Kaghan and more recently in Nathia Gali.

"But now with traffic hundred times higher, we may need hard top roads to reduce dust, noise and vehicles getting stuck in snow and for them not to go astray and remain in the designated area.

He also stressed the need for better campsite management, garbage disposal and upgraded restaurants, adding that education will have a key role to play in any betterment.

ATC extends Bushra Bibi PTI leaders' bail in Nov 26 protest case

ISLAMABAD: Anti-Terrorism Court (ATC) Judge Abual Hasanat Mohammad Zulqarnain on Monday extended the pre-arrest bail of Bushra Bibi, Omar Ayub Khan and several other PTI leaders in cases pertaining to the Nov 26 protest and demonstrations held outside the Supreme Court.

During the hearing, PTI leaders Sher Afzal Marwat and former Azad Jammu and Kashmir prime minister Abdul Qayyum Niazi appeared before the court, while exemption applications filed on behalf of Omar Ayub, Zartaj Gul and others were accepted.

The court observed that over 240 bail pleas of PTI leaders were pending and directed the parties to present arguments at the next hearing of the case on November 13. Cases against PTI leaders have been registered with Ramna, Sangjani, Tarnol and other police stations.

Meanwhile, ATC Judge Tahir Abbas Sipra conducted proceedings in connected cases, where he noted that the letter written by the PTI founder requesting a jail trial in the Nov 26 election rigging and Azadi March protest cases had not yet received a response from authorities concerned.

"If the state is serious about pursuing these cases, it should decide soon," the judge remarked, adding that he would send a reminder on the matter. The court also distributed copies of the challan in the Kohsar police station case.

During proceedings, exemption applications were also filed by Omar Ayub and Ali Nawaz Awan. Referring to a viral video of Omar Ayub, Judge Sipra observed that "Omar Ayub is flying in the wind; he would have fallen ill in the courtroom".

Defence counsel, however, clarified that the video was old and not recent.

Separately, the proceeding to indict KP Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur in the audio leak case pending before an additional district and sessions judge was postponed once again.—Malik Asad

Linking education with skills can bring back dropout children to school: state minister

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Says community engagement, addressing economic causes, positive use of modern technology are indispensable

By Kashif Abbasi

ISLAMABAD: Many children are forced to drop out of school to support their families economically. By linking education with skills, such children can be brought back to classrooms as parents will see both education and long-term livelihood opportunities for their children.

This was stated by Minister of State for Federal Education and Professional Training Wajiha Qamar on Monday while speaking at a ceremony on 'Promoting Literacy through Digitalisation' in collaboration with the Ministry of

Education, Jica-AQAL, the Pakistan Institute of Education, and the National Commission for Human Development.

Ms Qamar emphasised that without fostering a sense of collective ownership, true progress in education could not be achieved. Alongside the growing challenge of population increase, she stressed that community engagement, addressing the economic causes that keep children out of school, and the positive use of modern technology were indispensable.

Federal Secretary for Education Nadeem Mahbub, Director General Pakistan Institute of Education Dr Shahid Soroya, Jica Specialist for Youth and Adult Literacy Bilal Aziz, education ministry's focal person Sana Isa, Unesco Country Representative Fuad Pashayev and other stakeholders attended the event.

Minister Wajiha Qamar and Education Secretary Nadeem Mahbub also launched two key initiatives — 'NFE Teachers Professional Development

Framework and NFE Monitoring and Evaluation Mechanism' — as part of the ministry's larger NFE reforms.

The state minister reiterated that education emergency was not only about enrolling out-of-school children but also about ensuring quality education and improved learning environments for those already in schools.

She also highlighted initiatives such as the Ministry of Education's partnership with the Ministry of IT to launch programmes on TikTok to spread awareness about literacy and digital learning, noting that more such platforms could be leveraged effectively.

The minister praised the efforts of Secretary Nadeem Mahbub, Jica, Unesco and AIOU, while commending the technical leadership of PIE DG Dr Shahid Soroya.

Federal Education Secretary Nadeem Mahbub underscored that literacy was not just a fundamental right but also the basis of Pakistan's social cohesion, economic growth and democratic stability.

He recalled that the prime minister imposed a National Education Emergency in May 2024, under which the ministry was leading efforts to promote literacy and non-formal education. A comprehensive Non-Formal Education Policy Framework was being finalised, covering second-chance education, digital literacy and access for marginalised groups.

He further said the national target was to enroll 25.3 million children in schools and provide literacy opportunities to 70 million adults. Under the 'Each One Teach One' campaign, every literate individual will educate one illiterate person. Flexible education models are being introduced through BECS and NEF, while e-learning platforms and mobile applications will make education more accessible and inclusive.

He added that students completing five grades under the non-formal system would now be examined and certified by the Federal Directorate of Education, making them eligible for admission into grade six.

AIOU Vice Chancellor Dr Nasir Mahmood highlighted that Pakistan's literacy rate rises by only one per cent against a 2.7 per cent



MINISTER of State for Federal Education Wajiha Qamar speaks at a seminar on 'Promoting Literacy Era' in Islamabad on Monday. — APP

annual population growth, making targets difficult to achieve. He pointed out that the problem lies more in implementation than in policy design.

NCHD Director General Ali Asghar stated that the commission had introduced the "Each One Teach One" programme at the district level, participating actively in the education emergency. This year, NCHD aims to bring 100,000 identified out-of-school children into the

education system.

DG PIE Dr Mohammad Shahid Soroya presented data on literacy trends in Pakistan, while MoFEPT focal person Sana Isa gave a presentation on the ministry's non-formal education reforms.

Jica and PIE also shared insights on digital literacy, and Unesco Country Representative Fuad Pashayev highlighted Unesco's initiatives and support for literacy improvement in Pakistan.

Peace in South Asia hinges on mutual respect: minister

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By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: Information Minister Attaullah Tarar on Monday regretted that despite Pakistan's best efforts for peace, relationship with India had remained mired in deep-rooted mistrust mainly because of the latter's hegemonic designs in the region.

He recalled how in May 2025, India's military aggression was countered by Pakistan effectively.

"Peace in South Asia can only be obtained if all neighbours abide by the principle of mutual respect for each other's sovereignty, the minister said while speaking at the launch event of a new book on Pakistan-India relations. Former ambassador Aizaz Ahmad Chaudhry is the book's author.

The book launch event was organised jointly by Institute of Regional Studies Islamabad and Sanobar Institute Islamabad.

The minister commended the author for

writing this book at a time when it was important for the world to understand the dynamics underpinning tensions in South Asia and Pakistan's role for regional peace.

Mr Tarar recommended the book to scholars, researchers and observers of Pakistan-India relations.

The new book titled 'Pakistan-India Relations — Fractured Past, Uncertain Future' dealt with key aspects of the relationship between the two neighbours. Introducing the book, Ambassador Chaudhry informed the audience that it raised a fundamental question and then seeks to answer it: Is the failure to establish good neighbourliness because of the unresolved disputes or is there a larger dynamic in play?

The book examines the reasons behind India's refusal to resolve the Kashmir dispute, its politicisation of the issue of terrorism, and quest for regional assertiveness. It also examines the mistakes of the past and

explores whether a different and more hopeful future might yet be possible for South Asia.

Earlier, President of Institute of Regional Studies retired Ambassador Jauhar Saleem called upon the present Indian leadership to shift away from zero-sum thinking and move toward a framework based on mutual respect with opportunities for peaceful coexistence.

Engineer Khurram Dastgir recalled how since its independence Pakistan had countenanced Indian hostility and bellicosity. He observed that under the leadership of the Modi-led BJP, India had pursued its Hinduva-based narratives much more intensely than in the past.

President's spokesperson Murtaza Solangi spoke about the recent military aggression by India that was effectively and robustly countered by Pakistan.

Mr Solangi referred to the chapter of the book on May 2025 confrontation that explained in detail

how India's quest for dominance would remain a major source of regional instability.

Former president of National Defence University retired Lt Gen Aamer Riaz commended the detailed manner in which the book had explained how India's obstructionist attitude had kept the Kashmir dispute unresolved.

He also alluded to the book chapter on terrorism, which clearly underlined that India's bogey of cross-border terrorism was used politically rather than objectively.

Professor Arshi Saleem Hashmi, Dean of the Faculty of Contemporary Studies at the National Defence University, expressed her commendation for the last chapter of the book, which brings on record a large number of agreements and confidence building measures, to potentially serve as solid foundation for cooperation should there be a government in India that would wish to rethink its hostile policy towards Pakistan.

Azad Kashmir police dismantle protesting employees camp

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MUZAFFARABAD: Police on Monday dismantled a protest camp of former ad-hoc employees at a busy roundabout outside the Press Club, using 'mild baton charge' to disperse the participants and detaining some of them, including leaders of the movement.

The demonstrators, including several women, had set up a sit-in at the site to press for the regularisation of their services.

Assistant Commissioner Syed Ghulam Mohiuddin Gillani said he had requested the protesters to vacate the location as their camp was disrupting traffic and causing inconvenience to the public.

He claimed the administration had offered them the parking lot in front of the Deputy Commissioner's office as an alternative venue, but the protesters refused, prompting police action. However, the striking employees maintained that in September last year two ministers and the Deputy Commissioner had given a written agreement at the very same spot, pledging to resolve their

issues within 45 days — but even after a year no progress had been made.

They also pointed out that formal permission had been sought from the Deputy Commissioner Muzaffarabad 14 days earlier for the present sit-in, yet the administration forcibly dismantled their camp without justification. The protesters further alleged that police baton-charged women participants and arrested four leaders, one of whom sustained a head injury.

Despite the removal of their canopy and floor mats, the former ad hoc employees continued their sit-in under the open sky and by evening arranged mats to carry it on.

"No matter how much oppression the administration and government unleash, we will not leave this place until our demands are accepted," they declared.

However, late at night Assistant Commissioner Gillani held successful negotiations with the protesters, persuading them to end their sit-in. A delegation of the former ad-hoc employees will meet the senior-most minister on Tuesday, he said. — Staff Correspondent

Dedicated Freight Corridor to strengthen railways' revenue base: Abbasi

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RAWALPINDI: Minister for Railways Hanif Abbasi on Monday said the Dedicated Freight Corridor project would not only modernise freight transportation but also strengthen Pakistan Railways' revenue base through freight charges, track access fees and revenue-sharing mechanisms.

Speaking at the signing ceremony of Phase-I of the Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) hosted by the Ministry of Railways, the minister said the project would prove to be a milestone for Pakistan Railways.

DP World, Dubai-based global logistics company, is partnering with the NLC to complete this project.

The project was recently approved during a meeting of Cabinet Committee on Inter-Governmental Commercial Transactions (CCoIGCT), chaired by Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar.

Hanif Abbasi emphasised that the government was fully committed to launching Phase-I of the DFC at the earliest, reflecting the prime minister's vision of transforming Pakistan

Railways into a key driver of trade facilitation and modernisation.

He expressed deep gratitude to DP World and the Government of the UAE for their valuable support, stating that their collaboration marks the beginning of a new era for Pakistan Railways.

This landmark project will significantly enhance Pakistan Railways' freight capacity, enabling faster movement of cargo to and from Karachi Port, while also reducing congestion on roads and at the port.

It may be mentioned here that the term sheet of the project was signed in January 2025 between DP World/NLC and Pakistan Railways.

The railways officials said the sea freight arriving at Karachi Port was mainly being disposed of inland through road transport due to poor rail connectivity.

The NLC and DP World are already engaged in global logistic activities as recently both the companies have shipped over 1,000 containers between Pakistan and Bangladesh. — Staff Reporter

Imaan Mazari, Hadi Ali Chatha granted interim bail

By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: An additional district and sessions court on Monday granted interim bail to advocates Imaan Mazari and Hadi Ali Chatha in a case registered against them on the charges of alleged anti-state activities on social media.

Additional District and Sessions Judge Mohammad Afzal Majoka heard the bail applications and approved interim bail for both the lawyers. The judge restrained the National Cybercrime Investigation Agency (NCIA) from arresting them. The court also issued notices to NCIA for submission of its response and adjourned the hearing until September 11.

According to the FIR registered by the NCIA, Ms Mazari and Mr Chatha were accused of attempting to incite divisions on linguistic grounds through social media posts and of creating the impression that the armed forces were engaged in terrorism within the country.

The FIR alleged that they held security forces responsible for cases of missing persons in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan.

It stated that Ms Mazari and Mr Chatha had portrayed the armed forces as ineffective against proscribed groups, including Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA) and Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP).

The case has been registered under sections 9, 10, 11 and 26 of the Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act (Peca).

Four judges boycott full court deliberations

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control, the letter said. "It is a fallacious purpose, one that undermines the collective authority of this court," it added.

The judges claimed that they did not see any point in attending a meeting that was premised on amending rules which, according to their opinion, had already suffered from illegality both in substance and in process. They said the working paper also recorded that some initial input had been received from the

legal community, which was yet to be considered by the committee. "At the outset, we must reiterate the objection we have consistently raised that the present rules were never placed before, nor approved by, the full court in the first instance," they emphasised.

"This omission is not merely procedural but goes to the very root of legality as Article 191 of the Constitution vests the Supreme Court with the power to make rules regulating its practice and procedure, but this power is

exercised collectively by the court as an institution," the letter stated. It added that the rules framed without prior deliberations and approval of the full court lacked the imprimatur of the court itself and could not acquire binding legal status.

The judges said what compounded this infirmity was the method adopted for "approval".

The rules were processed through circulation, an administrative convenience to deal with routine or minor procedural matters; it is not, and cannot be, the vehicle for laying down the constitutional architecture of this court's governance.

Unless the full court itself had expressly resolved to adopt circulation for this purpose, the CJP alone could not unilaterally resort to it, the judges argued.

The judges demanded that their "objections be fully recorded in the minutes of the meeting and that the minutes of the full court be made public".

People are entitled to know how rules governing the internal life of the court came to be notified without discussion or deliberation amongst its judges, and how a post-facto meeting was being used to cloak that process in a semblance of legitimacy, they remarked.

Full court proceedings

At the outset of the full

court meeting, the CJP welcomed the participants and commended the efforts of the committee constituted to review the SC Rules, 1980 and appreciated the four-judge committee's exhaustive work, undertaken with input from judges and the legal fraternity, resulting in a comprehensive draft of the rules.

Justice Shahid Waheed, chairman of the committee, briefed the full court on the rules and after detailed deliberations, the full court agreed that the new rules were a "living document", and would be subject to review and amendment as required from time to time.

After considering different aspects and deliberating upon some of the critical provisions, the full court decided to postpone the implementation of amendments to the extent of enhancement of court fees and securities for the time being. The committee will consider the suggestions from judges, the bar representatives or other stakeholders in this regard for placement before the full court for a decision in light of recommendations.

The CJP termed this development a significant milestone, reflecting the judiciary's commitment to strengthening institutional frameworks and ensuring that the rules remain dynamic, responsive, and in line with contemporary needs.

AGP denies errors, defends integrity of audit reports

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said that the approval of the reports from the president was duly communicated through the President's Secretariat on April 12, 2025. Following this, the required number of federal audit reports were printed for laying before both houses of parliament.

On the AGP's request, the motions were included in the National Assembly's Orders of the Day issued on August 13, 2025. However, the National Assembly Secretariat, through its deputy secretary (legislation), informed the same day that the assembly session had been prorogued. As a result, the motion for laying the reports could not be included in

the Orders of the Day.

The secretariat further asked that the reports be collected from the legislation branch, with due observance of confidentiality until they are formally laid before the house. "It is further clarified that the audit reports transmitted to the Senate remain in the custody of the Senate Secretariat," it added.

Based on this record, the DAGP said: "The news currently circulating in different sections of print media alleging miscalculations in the audit reports and claiming that these reports were returned to the Department of the Auditor-General of Pakistan by the National Assembly Secretariat are entirely

unfounded and misleading."

It stressed that the audit reports, appropriation accounts and financial statements were sent to the NA Secretariat after the president's approval on the prime minister's advice to lay them before both houses of parliament.

Defending the integrity of its audit findings, the AGP asserted that the reports were prepared after proper quality assurance and "did not contain any errors". It explained that the figures cited in the media came only from the executive summary of the consolidated federal audit report for 2024-25, which is prepared as a reference document to help stakeholders access and review sector-wise findings.

Strike brings Quetta to standstill

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Wadan, BNP-Mengal leader Mir Naseer Ahmed Shahwani and others were also arrested by the police.

Private educational institutions, including schools and colleges, remained closed due to the protest.

However, government-run educational institutions and offices remained open, but very few employees could reach the secretariat and other offices due to low traffic.

60 arrested across province

In other parts of the province, over 60 people were arrested for violating Section 144, blocking the highways, and clashing with the security forces. The wheel-jam and shutter-down strike was also observed in Loralai, Zhob, Sibi, Nasirabad, Khuzdar, Kalat, Harnai, Mastung, Hub Bela, Kharan, Noshki, Qila Saifullah, Turbat, Panjgur, Gwadar, Dera Murad Jamali and other towns and cities.

“Around 60 people were arrested in these towns,” said officials.

In KP, the opposition parties, as well as the ruling PTI, also organised demonstrations across the province.

The strike call was given by PkMAP, BNP, the PTI, the ANP, the National Party, and the MWM at a joint presser last week to protest the Sept 2 suicide bombing.

Sardar Akhtar Mengal, Mehmood Khan Achakzai, former senator Mir Kabir Muhammad Shahi, and ANP leader Asghar Achakzai remained unhurt in the attack as they had left just a few minutes before.

Press conference

Addressing the media at the Quetta Press Club on Monday evening, PkMAP's Lala Abdul Rauf, BNP's Sajid Tareen Advocate, ANP's Asghar Achakzai, National Party's Aslam Baloch, Jamaat-e-Islami's Zahid Akhtar, and PTI's Dawood Shah Achakzai condemned what they called

the government's attempts to sabotage their strike. They decried baton charge, tear gas shelling, and mass arrests of peaceful protesters and announced a plan to hold more protest rallies.

The leaders announced that protests will be held on Sept 11 in front of press clubs across Balochistan, while a meeting of senior leaders has been scheduled for Sept 13 to finalise the alliance's future course of action. They warned that if political workers and leaders detained across the province were not released, a tougher line of action would be announced at the Sept 13 meeting.

Former governor Malik Abdul Wali Kakar, Akhtar Hussain Langove, Shafqaat Langove, Jameel Mashwani, Abdul Hameed Mansoori, Mir Ghulam Nabi Marri, Kabir Afghan, and Ismatullah were also present at the press conference.

Behram Baloch, Ali Jan Mangi, and Abdul Wahid Shahwani also contributed

Flood devastation

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the total area, remained under floodwaters.

The floods have devastated key crops, including rice, sugarcane, corn, vegetables, and cotton. According to the Pakistan Business Forum, approximately 35pc of the cotton crop in central and southern Punjab has been destroyed, with losses reaching as high as 40-50pc in Bahawalnagar, the province's largest cotton-producing district.

Akhtar Farooq Meo of the Kissan Board Pakistan claimed that farmers sustained losses to the tune of Rs536 billion due to damage to the cotton, rice, sesame, maize, and fodder crops. Mr Meo claimed that many towns were facing shortages of perishable items and the situation could transform into a food crisis.

Meanwhile, there were conflicting reports about damage to the rice crop. The Pakistan Business Forum claimed that 60pc of the rice crop in central and southern Punjab had been destroyed — a claim contested by the exporters.

They said the Basmati crop region, with the exception of Pasrur in Sialkot, remained largely undam-

aged, adding that the non-Basmati crop, particularly along the Sutlej River, had already been harvested in late July and early August, with only hybrid varieties in some areas sustaining damage.

However, floods created a severe shortage of fodder, threatening the livestock industry, which was a major contributor to the national GDP.

Meanwhile, experts feared a sharp rise in domestic grain prices that could make Pakistani rice uncompetitive on the global market. Similarly, the loss of the cotton crop was also alarming for the textile industry, accounting for over half of Pakistan's export revenues.

Ihsanul Haq, the chairman of the Cotton Ginners Forum, said the crop was under severe stress.

Major cotton-producing regions in Punjab and Sindh, including Bahawalnagar, Multan, Bahawalpur, and Rahim Yar Khan, were either currently submerged or were bracing for more heavy rainfall. The reduced supply of raw cotton reportedly forced several ginning factories and mills to cease operations. Furthermore, there were early reports of a virus affecting various cotton varieties, which could further reduce per-acre yields.

\$7bn ML-1 financing consortium

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deepening strategic cooperation and advancing the shared vision of an even closer partnership in the new era between two “time-tested, friendly countries.”

The two sides agreed to make full use of the Framework Agreement on Industrial Cooperation to accelerate industrialisation, support exports and encourage Chinese firms to invest in Pakistan, including in the mining sector and building mining industrial parks.

They also agreed to

promote cooperation in crop cultivation, animal husbandry, epidemic control for plants and animals, aquaculture, agro-processing, agricultural mechanisation and capacity building in seed technology and drip irrigation.

The plan includes aligning the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) with Pakistan’s 5Es Framework, implementing both large-scale landmark projects and “small and beautiful” livelihood projects, while ensuring both high-quality development and robust security.

Balochistan PA approves two bills, refers third to panel for review

Lawmakers express concern over illegal trawling in coastal areas despite ban

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: The Balochistan Assembly on Monday passed the Balochistan Institute of Cardiovascular Diseases (Amendment) Bill, 2025, and the Balochistan Land Revenue (Amendment) Bill, 2025, and referred the Balochistan Institute of Nephro-Urology (Amendment) Bill, 2025, back to the standing committee for further review.

The House also referred audit reports of the Hazar Ganji bus terminal in Quetta and the Gwadar-Lasbela Support Project for years 2012-13 to 2020-21 to the public accounts committee.

The Speaker issued a ruling making it mandatory for secretaries of relevant departments to attend assembly proceedings whenever matters concerning their departments are on the agenda.

The JI Provincial Emir and MPA Maulana Hidayatur Rehman raised a calling attention notice about the disruption of electricity supply from Iran to Makran, particularly Gwadar.

He said that despite an agreement for 100 megawatts (MW), only 10MW were being supplied, leaving the people in severe distress. After a reply from the parliamentary secretary for energy, the notice was disposed of.

The JI lawmaker also criticised the Social Welfare Department, alleging that 140 employees posted in Gwadar had not been performing their duties. Parliamentary Secretary Wali Noorzai confirmed absenteeism and said disciplinary action is under way, promising to present the findings to

the House.

Provincial Health Minister Bakht Muhammad Kakar moved the Cardiovascular Institute Amendment Bill, which was passed.

However, when he introduced the Nephro-Urology amendment bill, lawmakers Dr Nawaz Kakar and Syed Zafar Agha raised objections, urging a fresh review. The Speaker accepted their demand and referred the bill back to the committee, directing it to reconvene on Tuesday and bring final recommendations for approval at the next session.

On a point of order, Maulana Hidayatur Rehman complained that departmental secretaries often remained absent from the Assembly, showing disrespect to elected representatives.

The provincial assembly Speaker ruled that the chief secretary must ensure that secretaries attend sessions, warning of action if the order was ignored.

Lawmakers also raised concern about illegal trawling in coastal areas of Balochistan despite an official ban, which they said was happening with the connivance of the Fisheries Department of the province, depriving local fishermen of their livelihood.

Lawmakers from Nasirabad complained about suspension of power supply to agricultural tube-wells before their conversion to solar energy, prompting the Speaker of the provincial assembly to summon the energy secretary and Qesco chief to the assembly on Wednesday.

Provincial Minister Sardarzada Faisal Jamali warned of possible flooding in Nasirabad from expected high flows at Guddu and Sukkur barrages and called for coordination between the Balochistan and Sindh governments.

Finance Minister Mir Shoaib Noshervani assured the House that PDMA officials were already in the field to monitor the situation.

CM Bugti vows terrorism cleanup, better governance

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Urges political stakeholders to move beyond 'non-issues' and focus on real development challenges

By Ali Jan Mangi

DERA MURAD JAMALI: Balochistan Chief Minister Mir Sarfraz Bugti has declared the elimination of terrorism and the improvement of governance as the province's foremost priorities.

Speaking at an open kachehry in the Bhekar area of Dera Bugti district, he urged political stakeholders to move beyond "non-issues" and focus on the real challenges hindering development.

The event drew a large turnout of citizens and members of the provincial assembly, offering a rare platform for direct public engagement.

CM Bugti listened attentively to public grievances and issued immediate directives to officials, reaffirming his administration's commitment to swift and practical solutions.

The chief minister described terror-

ism as a "cancer" that has deeply affected all segments of society. He commended the sacrifices made by the people of Dera Bugti in their pursuit of peace and national unity, emphasising that the integrity of the state must be upheld at all costs.

He warned against the practice of linking everyday societal issues with state responsibilities, stressing that such narratives undermine national cohesion.

"The government's doors are open to all," he assured, highlighting his commitment to inclusive and responsive governance.

While affirming the public's right to peaceful protest, the chief minister condemned disruptive actions such as road blockades, warning that coercion and violence will not be tolerated. He called for responsible civic engagement that respects public convenience and national dignity.

To enhance service delivery at the grassroots level, CM Bugti directed local government representatives to adopt a more proactive approach. He reiterated the provincial government's commitment to providing development funds to local bodies, contingent upon transparency and alignment with national values.

GB prepares proposal for PM committee to restore trade

Page 5

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: A 50-day-long protest sit-in intensified on Monday as traders in Gilgit-Baltistan (GB) shut down a customs and immigration office in Sost, blocking the Karakoram Highway and stranding thousands of travellers headed to China via the Khunjerab Pass.

Traders have suspended all trade and travel activities, demanding the implementation of a two-point agenda related to taxation and stuck import consignments.

In response to the crisis, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif recently announced a one-time amnesty for the stuck consignments and formed a committee, chaired by Federal Minister for Power Division Awais Leghari, to find a resolution.

The GB cabinet submitted recommendations endorsing the traders' demands and asking that the region be declared a non-tariff area. After the federal committee sent the recommendations back for review, the GB chief minister constituted a new nine-member committee on Thursday.

The new committee has recommended that all goods imported exclusively for consumption in GB be treated as tax-free and has suggested a special relief grant for traders to mitigate their financial losses.

It also suggested a special Consolidated SRO should be introduced to grant tax exemption for GB.

Other recommendations include withdrawing a SRO 499/2009 imposed on certain containers, re-assessment and re-evaluation of those containers, waiving all demurrage charges, and delegating judicial powers to the local collector to expedite cases.

The committee's recommendation is expected to receive approval from the GB cabinet and will be submitted to the prime minister's committee this week.

Protesters have announced they will continue their peaceful demonstration until their demands are accepted. They closed all entry and exit points for passengers between the two countries. The protest has garnered wider support, with a large solidarity demonstration held outside the GB Assembly hall in Gilgit.

Women protest marathon exclusion

Meanwhile, female athletes are protesting after being excluded from the inaugural Sarfaranga National Marathon scheduled for Sept 14 at the Sarfaranga cold desert in Shigar.

The GB government, which announced the marathon as part of its Sarfaranga festival, initially sought applications from both male and female runners for the event, setting an online registration deadline of Sept 14.

However, after women registered and paid the required bank deposit of Rs1000, the online application form was changed only to have male as a selectable option available.

Mona Khan, a woman adventurer from Islamabad, said that after she submitted her registration and fee, the application browser then showed only a male option.

"When we talked to officials, they said only males can participate in the Marathon and women have been excluded," she said.

Officials from Gilgit-Baltistan government departments did not respond to *Dawn's* requests for comment.

Leaky state

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THE authorities should not feign alarm: after all, they have been repeatedly warned against the compulsion to 'keep files' on all and sundry — guilty and innocent alike. Invasive surveillance and data-gathering on citizens creates a massive liability because the state must assume all responsibility for the information it collects. There can be extreme consequences in case of failure, and this is precisely what has happened in the latest leak of citizens' personal data, which not only compromises thousands of ordinary citizens, but government officials and federal ministers as well. Peel back the headlines, and the questions left are why were such extensive details — including what mobile SIMs they own, what their CNICs look like, their call logs, identity documents, and even their international travel histories — being collected, and who was doing the collecting? More gravely, how did all this data leak into the open? Were those doing the spying also compromised?

The National Cyber Crimes Investigation Agency has now formed a special team to investigate the matter on the special directives of Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi, whose own data is said to be among the caches being sold freely on the web, sometimes for as little as Rs500. The relevant press release issued by his ministry promises that those involved in the data leak will be identified and brought to justice. If, indeed, anyone is caught — and that is a big if — the damage may already be done by the time they are brought to justice, mainly because the government is not in any position to secure the leaked data and prevent it from falling into the wrong hands. All of the compiled information is now reportedly just a Google search away from cybercriminals. Therefore, instead of finding scapegoats, the authority would be better served with a bit of self-reflection.

Investigating how the data leaked will be important, but it would seem much more necessary for the state to ask itself why it needs such expansive surveillance of its own citizens. Clearly, the premise it works on is that nobody can be trusted; however, as the repeated leaks of sensitive data continue to show, even security agencies cannot be trusted to be fully 'secure' themselves. Secondly, why are our national cybersecurity capabilities so weak that massive breaches of sensitive data continue to occur with such alarming frequency? It may be recalled that, just a few months ago, the National Cyber Emergency Response Team warned that the login credentials and passwords of 180m Pakistanis were exposed online. Last year, it emerged that data on 2.7m citizens had been compromised due to weak cybersecurity controls at Nadra. When even citizens' fingerprints can be put up for sale, what is safe? And what can the state be trusted with safekeeping?

Cancer burden

IT has been a long time coming. Finally, Pakistan is set to create a national cancer registry after President Asif Ali Zardari signed into law a bill reorganising the National Institutes of Health. The NIH will now be tasked with maintaining a central database of cancer cases. The hope is that this registry will provide a clear picture of the country's true cancer burden. At present, the numbers are guesswork. The Global Cancer Observatory recorded 178,388 cases in Pakistan in 2020, but these were largely based on the Punjab Cancer Registry, which covers only parts of Lahore and central Punjab. Extrapolating from such a narrow base to a country of 240m people is a recipe for undercounting. Official figures almost certainly underestimate the problem. The result is that health policy is crafted in the dark, treatment capacity is misallocated and awareness campaigns are scattershot. A functioning national registry could change this. By recording confirmed cases, deaths, recoveries and demographic data — such as age, gender and location — policymakers will have a sharper tool for designing prevention programmes and allocating resources. Researchers will gain access to a dataset that can identify patterns — whether in lifestyle, environment or genetics — that raise cancer risk. International donors and research bodies, long wary of our patchy data, may be more willing to invest in programmes once the scale of the problem is better understood.

But registries are only as good as the systems that feed them. Previous attempts at a national registry failed for lack of resources and institutional coordination. Pakistan's health infrastructure is fragmented, underfunded and overly reliant on ad hoc donor projects. Rural areas, where medical records are sparse, will be particularly difficult to capture. Ensuring patient privacy, as the bill promises, will also be vital to maintaining public trust. The registry, in short, is a necessary but insufficient reform. It will provide the map. But maps are useless without vehicles to traverse them — and without leaders willing to steer those vehicles towards meaningful progress. Pakistan must pair this initiative with stronger cancer screening programmes, more oncology centres outside big cities and expanded palliative care. Cancer is rising sharply in low- and middle-income countries. Without investment in treatment and prevention, Pakistan risks turning this new database into nothing more than a bleak national roll-call.

Sign of hope

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HALFWAY through the T20 tri-nation series final, it seemed as if Pakistan had not done enough. Afghanistan were in the ascendancy in Sharjah and Salman Ali Agha's men needed someone to step up — a match-winner. Enter Mohammad Nawaz: the spinner, who took five wickets, completed a hat-trick and secured a thumping 75-run victory for Pakistan. Salman's men had mastered the conditions — and a turning pitch. Their triumph augurs well for the upcoming T20 Asia Cup, which will also be held in the UAE. Pakistan are a team in transition, having dispensed with batting stalwarts Babar Azam and Mohammad Rizwan. Yet, this was their 10th victory in 14 T20 Internationals since Mike Hesson took over as limited-overs head coach. However, those games were against the likes of Bangladesh, the West Indies, Afghanistan and the UAE. Bigger tests await Pakistan in the Asia Cup, especially the clash against arch-rivals and world champions India — the first game between the neighbours since the four-day conflict this year. In a relatively straightforward group, which includes Oman and the UAE, this is the fixture that will indicate where Pakistan stand. The T20 World Cup will be held next year and the Pakistan Cricket Board wants to maximise the number of matches to help the team gel further. Pakistan host South Africa across three formats, including a three-game T20 series, starting October and will then host Sri Lanka and Afghanistan in a tri-series the following month.

The aim now should be to trust the head coach and the process. The PCB has been trigger-happy in Mohsin Naqvi's tenure as chairman, with a revolving door for coaches, players and selectors. Coach Hesson has shortlisted players that he feels will take the T20 team forward. In the victory against Afghanistan, Pakistan showed adaptability. It was not about being gung-ho from the first ball. Salman said Pakistan was finally in good shape. Now the emphasis should be on continuity.



End to trade diplomacy?

The new tariff policy poses a risk to external sector stability and the current account surplus.

The era of naive globalisation is coming to an end with nations turning inward and prioritising their own interests. — Donald Tusk, Polish prime minister

WHILE one cannot say for sure what was in the minds of those who approved the new National Tariff Policy 2025-2030, they were definitely not looking at the prevalent global trade scene. The new policy seems to draw its inspiration from the 'neoliberal orthodoxy' fast becoming redundant in these challenging times, which columnist Gillian Tett describes as "a new era of 'geo-economics'" where state-driven industrial policies — tariffs, export controls — are reshaping global trade."

In the 1980s, leaders such as Margaret Thatcher and Ronald Reagan supported the free-market ideas espoused by politicians such as Jack Kemp and economists such as Eugene Fama and Milton Friedman. They assumed that "markets and money were shaped by laws of supply and demand so consistent and universal that they could be modelled using tools from physics and math". The myth did not survive even in the best of the times when global free trade policy in the World Trade Organisation was led initially by the US or later by China.

Even before the world saw the US-China trade war heat up, using tariffs and subsidies to influence flow of trade, globalisation and market access had been restricted through customs unions/ trade blocs such as Asean, the EU, EAEU, GCC and many others. The countries have been engaging with each other and these trade blocs, to gain market access through free or preferential trade agreements (FTAs/ PTAs). One of the main reasons for Pakistan facing difficulty in expanding its exports is that it has only few FTAs/ PTAs as compared to its competitors. That is to say, it has limited market access.

This is not the first time that we went down the path of old-fashioned romanticism with the ideas of free trade and tariff liberalisation. The rationale was always the same: global integration, competitiveness and efficiency. The outcomes, however, tell a different story.

We should have kept in mind the lessons from the liberalisation era of the 1990s under the IMF

and World Bank structural adjustment programmes. It was said that tariff rationalisation would modernise trade and integrate the economy into the global market. Between 1996 and 2005, Pakistan's average tariff was steeply brought down from 46.6 per cent to just 14.3pc. Instead of expanding exports, Pakistan entered into an unending spiral of high trade deficits eating away workers' remittances and leaving behind large current account deficits. The trade deficit which was just \$3.1 billion in 1995-96 grew four times to \$12.1bn in 2005-06 and 16 times to \$48.3bn in 2021-22.

In three decades (1995-2025) Pakistan's exports increased only 3.7 times from \$8.7bn to \$32.3bn. In these 30 years, the export of regional peers, ie, Bangladesh and India, grew by 12.6 and 14.3 times, respectively. In contrast, our imports jumped almost eight times, from \$11.8bn in 1995-96 to \$80.3bn, its highest in 2021-22.

The unilateral opening of our markets to foreign goods, without an accompanying industrial policy which would have allowed our industry to grow from producers of low-value goods to high-value ones, left our industries facing their worst downward spiral into an era of premature de-industrialisation. In these three decades, Pakistan's industrial sector recorded only a six-fold increase, compared with 30-fold in Vietnam, 17-fold in Bangladesh, and nine-fold in India.

The National Tariff Policy 2025-30 seeks to reduce the average tariff from 10.4pc to below 6pc by 2030, far below the average tariff of around 16pc in India and 14pc in Bangladesh. The new structure reduces five slabs to four (0pc, 5pc, 10pc, 15pc), reducing from the current highest slab of 20pc. Bangladesh and India continue to retain their maximum slabs of 25pc and 70pc respectively, despite enjoying a much larger market access. Both our competitors continue to impose additional duties and surcharges, whereas Pakistan has committed to phase these out in four to five years under the new policy.

The previous National Tariff Policy 2019-24 distinguished between inputs essential for industrial development and luxury consumption goods, lowering duties on raw material, intermediate inputs and machinery while retaining

higher tariffs on finished and non-essential imports. It helped reduce production costs without exposing domestic firms to undue competition. If accompanied by the right policy mix, it could have provided the foundation for sustainable industrial growth.

Any attempt to trade liberalisation must be accompanied by a reasonably sound industrial base and enabling global environment. The new tariff policy puts the hard-earned stability in the external sector and the current account surplus achieved only last year, at immense risk. The knee-jerk tariff policy shift has shown the future trend in the first two months of its partial implementation. The trade deficit in the months of July and August jumped 29pc at \$6bn, up from \$4.6bn last year for the corresponding period against a 12.5pc decline in exports in the month of August.

As a market of 250 million consumers, Pakistan can attract many investors and traders if it can offer a profitable proposition through preferential tariff concessions to economies which make reciprocal concessions to our exporters and investors. If we open our market unilaterally for the entire world, giving away tariffs as a bargaining chip, why would anyone bother to discuss FTAs/ PTAs with us and open their markets for our exports?

"The world has changed, globalisation is over and we are now in a new era," said Keir Starmer, the British prime minister. We no longer live in the Reagan-Thatcher era of neoliberalism or globalisation. Let us put aside outdated editions of a redundant policy mix. Let us wake up to the new real world of smart trade deals, using tariff policy as a tool for negotiations and for exchanging market access, instead of allowing unilateral access. It must be accompanied by a reliable security environment, enabling policies and their continuity, and efficient protection for those industrial sectors that are critical for our economic security. ■

The writer was formerly a federal secretary and caretaker provincial minister. He is currently the chairman of the Policy Research and Advisory Council.

The US is nobody's ally



QUITE a few in India, America and Europe seem to have sighted a terrifying apparition with horns and canines as it were. A faux debate has been unleashed over Narendra Modi's televised pictures with the Chinese and Russian presidents at the SCO summit. Who lost India to China? The question is a non sequitur but it's doing fervent rounds even in a wryly smiling Pakistan. It's not clear from the visuals if Modi had cracked a joke to amuse the other two, if so in which language. Or whether the Russian or the Chinese had said something funny to make him guffaw. The truer picture could well be that a jilted Modi hijacked the occasion to thumb his nose at Donald Trump, accused of 'pushing' India into China's embrace.

Those accusing Trump of betraying India haven't learnt from history. They can't seem to see from the past what other Trumps have done to other Modis. Not unlike them Modi too is not ditching Trump for Xi Jinping or any other. Nor is India under Hindutva's watch walking away from the US.

Let's consider a few memorable examples of those that were stabbed in the back by the US but who still never had the courage to walk away. Take Europe. Nato? Closest allies? Of course, they are not. Look closely at the charade orchestrated to serve the interest of the UK and the US principally. Three remaining members of the Anglosphere from the Five Eyes — Canada, Australia and New Zealand — might be included if it interests the main two. Nato and Europe stand wrecked.

Thanks to Edward Snowden we learnt through documents he revealed that the US intelligence was monitoring chancellor Merkel's personal mobile phone. The surveillance reportedly began as early as 2002, before she even became chancellor, and continued until at least 2013. Merkel was reported to be furious, famously telling president Obama: "Spying among friends is never acceptable." It didn't end there for Germany. Joe Biden, according to compelling insights shared by Pulitzer winning Seymour Hersh, blew up the

undersea gas lifeline from Russia, choking Germany into obsequious submission to America.

WikiLeaks revealed how multiple French presidents and high-level French government officials were spied on over a period of years. The reports did not always specify which presidents, but the timeline suggests it included the administrations of Jacques Chirac, Nicolas Sarkozy, and François Hollande. Targeting France didn't end there. The US and the UK joined hands to set up AUKUS, a shell company with Australia, specifically to exclude France and stab President Macron in the back to steal a multibillion-dollar French submarine deal for the Anglo duo. Macron winced but that was that. When capitalism is in crisis it devours its own. Europe is experiencing it first-hand.

Those accusing Trump of betraying India haven't learnt from history.

Why would Modi not walk away from Trump? It's not only because a key capitalist friend is facing criminal charges in the US and might need the White House for presidential help if it came to that. Besides, the US has also named Indian intelligence as accomplices in a plot to assassinate Sikh Americans in America who Delhi sees as terrorists. (A worried Canada, evidently responding to the terror of Modi's pictures out of Tianjin, last week released an intelligence report singling out certain Sikh groups as fomenting terrorism in India. Advantage Modi.)

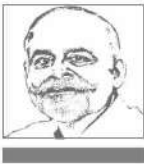
However, Modi has an overriding ideological affinity with the US. Hindutva groups derive financial and political sustenance from their presence in certain parts of the world, the US being the hub. If these groups were to try to set up shop in China, for example, they would likely be committed to a re-education regime à la

Muslim extremists of Xinjiang.

The BJP is America's oldest ally in India, occasionally embarrassingly so. Remember Atal Bihari Vajpayee shooting off a secret letter to Bill Clinton confiding how the 1998 nuclear tests were aimed at China. Clinton needed China's support at the time, and the letter got duly leaked. With Hindutva in the saddle in India, the country is not going anywhere without the US, never mind the insults and threats from the current White House. What is likelier to happen is that as BRICS chairperson next year, India, if it is still under Modi's spell, would use the occasion to water down the challenge the US rightly sees from BRICS. Modi's mantra is that BRICS is a bridge between the Global South and the West, which it is not. That's the role of G20. But that's the only way Modi can explain India's membership to Trump and his aides.

To the Indian middle classes, raised in the post-USSR crucible of free markets (which needs Hindutva to divert attention from the outcome — 800 million on food dole) — the question needs to be posed another way. What were other 'friendlier' post-Cold War US presidents doing while courting India? Clinton destroyed Yugoslavia. Bush ran amok in Iraq and Afghanistan. Obama dismantled Libya. Biden declared himself a Zionist and supervised the slaughter of Palestinians while starting a prairie fire in Ukraine to singe Russia. They all embraced India as a bulwark against China albeit with varying emphasis. There's a delectable line that comes to mind from Habib Jalib's versified description of Ziaul Haq's brutal dictatorship. "*Apne kharch par hain qaid, log tere raj mein.*" ("The masses are so delighted with you that they spend their own money to be lodged in your prisons") Jalib's line sits nicely with India arming itself to the teeth, paying an exorbitant price for foreign weapons to become a bulwark for a country that keeps no permanent friends. ■

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Ticking Titanic

THE Titanic sank after striking an iceberg that by some estimates was about 120 metres long and between 15m to 30m high. We are home to over 7,000 known glaciers; a recent study estimates the number at 13,000. Among them is the Kutiah Lungma glacier in Gilgit-Baltistan — 12 kilometres long and 3 km wide. Although glaciers have remained frozen for ages, they are now flowing towards us, and not at a glacial pace.

Neither global warming nor the presence of glaciers in Pakistan should surprise anyone. The World Bank has been warning since 2012 in its *Turn Down the Heat* series that the planet could see a four-degree Celsius temperature rise by the end of the century, enough to cause the oceans to boil over. It also estimates that by 2050, the combined effect of environmental degradation and climate change could lead to an 18 per cent to 20pc loss in Pakistan's GDP.

But what will surprise everyone is that till 2010, we never thought about monitoring our glaciers. A formal cryosphere monitoring programme was initiated only in 2019 at the Koshik glacier in the Karakoram range. Unfortunately, it is not a case of better late than never, as at least 30 years of data is required to understand the impact of climate change.

A report in this newspaper, a few months back, announced the completion of a project, albeit a restructured version of its original self. No prizes for guessing which part of the project was scrapped: the climate monitoring part.

The \$188 million Pakistan Hydromet and Climate Project supported by the World Bank, and in preparation since 2017, experienced its first restructuring within 10 days of becoming effective in 2020. The second restructuring of its development objectives occurred three years later. After 18 months of extension, the project closed down in December 2024 with an overall 'moderately satisfactory' rating. Really? — one must ask! The project, which aimed to develop weather and climate monitoring infrastructure to enable early warning systems for disaster mitigation was reduced to an emergency relief effort in the aftermath of the 2022 floods.

The implementing agencies — the NDMA, PDMA, the Met Department, the climate change and planning ministries, the centre and provinces — once again proved themselves unequal to the task. The original objective was allocated \$106m; it was revised down to \$60m, and then scrapped altogether, with \$0 spent on it. The emergency response component, which was originally not even part of the project, was allocated \$150m, disbursed as a one-time cash transfer of Rs25,000 to vulnera-

ble households.

For the uninitiated, no World Bank project could be amended or revised without the approval of its board of directors — hence making its management and board equally accountable for agreeing to such audacious changes to a development project by a member country's government. There is no harm in getting our share of the IFI loans. How we spend it is where the rub lies. Citizens should hold their governments responsible. The IFIs' management and boards should also be held accountable for flip-flopping between an opportunistic lender and the lender of last resort as it suits careers and their largest shareholders.

Some people argue that we should avoid borrowing for development because of the attached 'conditionalities'. But let me ask, would your best friend or even a sibling lend you money without asking, 'what is it for, how long will I have to wait, and how will you pay it back?' Remember, we are talking about a loan, not charity or aid,

Before 2010,
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which might be given without question. Those are your conditionalities that our self-styled alternative economists often criticise. Everything else — including but not limited to structural adjustments, spending cuts and

deficit ceilings — comes into play because we can't or won't answer the basic questions of why, what and when regarding the loan. The day we can confidently say we're borrowing for A, B or C, that we will pay it back when due, and that we will do so by generating revenue through a mix of exports and direct taxes, no one will be able to manipulate us into doing anything.

The glaciers are coming, and no Titanic, as we have now learned, will ever be 'unsinkable'. The orchestra on the Titanic played on until the last moment, ostensibly to keep up the passengers' spirits. The captain of this doomed ocean liner went down with it.

We seem to be following the script, only we have a band instead of an orchestra, and it plays Nero's tune on flutes, for we swing between burning and drowning thanks to our acts of omission and commission on climate change. As for the captains, they tend to jump ship the moment they have that sinking feeling. ■

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A consequential life

IN the summer of 1982, there was talk of a new medical college coming up in Karachi. It was to be Pakistan's first such institution in the private sector and was being launched by a highly reputed enterprise, the Aga Khan Development Network. An imposing boundary wall along Stadium Road testified to this emerging reality. For prospective medical students like me, this was electrifying news. In those days Pakistan's medical education landscape was in disarray because of politicised campuses, and the five-year MBBS programme was taking much longer.

Although there had been no official announcement, I made enquiries and came upon the name of a certain Dr Camer Vellani as the project's central figure. The phone directory listed a number for his clinic, which I dialled one evening with apprehension and anticipation. When Dr Vellani came on the line and took me through the basics of the project, I was hooked. The following year, I was fortunate to be admitted to the Aga Khan University Medical College's inaugural class, a group of 50 selected from an applicant pool of over 5,000.

The opening week included an orientation by Dr Vellani, who was associate dean. The moment he walked in, the room filled up with his quiet and dignified presence. A slender frame adorned with a scholarly bespectacled bearing, he spoke with a soft but commanding eloquence. After introductory remarks, he scribbled a searching question on the blackboard: "What am I doing here?" — emphasising each word one by one. A fundamental query was thus transformed into several, prodding us to self-reflect. You can judge the impact of that moment from the fact that it has stayed with my classmates and me ever since.

In 1985, when our clinical years began, we encountered Dr Vellani more often. He was founding chairman of the department of medicine and a decorated professor of medicine and cardiology. He taught us how to extract a systematic medical history and conduct an orderly physical examination. I happened to be one of the more excitable students in our class and would try Dr Vellani's patience from time to time, but he never betrayed any irritation or annoyance. His method was steady gentlemanly persuasion conveyed with calmness and composure.

Before long, we were all looking up to him not just as a teacher or mentor, but also as a father figure and a role model. We watched with rapt attention while he conducted his outpatient clinics, being unfailingly generous with his time and

wisdom to both patients and students alike. We stood mesmerised at the bedside as he elicited challenging physical signs, such as a third or fourth heart sound or an abnormally robust pulsation in the jugular vein. We sat captivated as he elaborated on the biological aspects of heart failure or, his particular favourite, the physics of electrocardiography. The long and short of it is that we outright idolised him.

Our class graduated in 1988 and scattered to pursue advanced specialisation in our chosen fields. I spent a decade in the US and returned in 2000 to join the Aga Khan faculty as assistant professor of neurology. During this time Dr Vellani had served in a series of leadership roles, including a term as rector (equivalent to vice chancellor). He was revered as a medical statesman, combining the qualities of a master clinician, an impactful academic and a seasoned administrator in one inspiring and edifying persona. I went to his office to pay my respects and to apologise for having been

—
'He made us want to be like him.'
—

rather a boisterous student. Dr Vellani would have none of it. He laughed a soft, gentle laugh and said "Saad, you never gave me any trouble." Then, with a twinkle and an affectionate smile he added,

"Well, perhaps just a little." I was quickly reminded of the many reasons we had admired and adored him.

For the last few months, the word got out that Dr Vellani was unwell, triggering widespread concern across the institution. Early on the morning of Sept 4, he breathed his last; he was 88. His body may have weakened, but his mind remained sharp. A colleague who was with him in the final hours heard him express gratitude at having been granted a blessed life; perhaps he had a premonition that his time had come. Dr Vellani had exited with the same dignified elegance that had marked him throughout his long and rewarding life, a life of unmatched dedication and exemplary service. He helped and healed generations of sick patients, and motivated and inspired legions of medical students towards clinical excellence. He made us want to be like him. If the most consequential measure of a life is the sum of your good deeds, then Dr Vellani rests most comfortably and the rest of us stand enriched. ■

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Action against NAP

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RAWALPINDI: The Attorney-General, Mr Yahya Bakhtiar, today [Sept 8] submitted before the Supreme Court that the evidence produced before the court showed that [the] Government took action against the National Awami Party on the basis of the material brought to its notice from time to time. It was not a subjective decision, he argued. The [AG] commenced his closing address today before the court hearing Government reference on dissolution of [NAP]. The closing address was still inconclusive when the court rose for the day... . . .Yahya Bakhtiar submitted that in his opening address of June 19, 20 and 23 last he gave an outline of the Government case... . . .[H]e also drew attention of the court to the anti-Pakistan designs of NAP ... in support of the Government contention that this party was operating in a manner prejudicial to the integrity ... of Pakistan. — News agencies

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from Beirut,] the Lebanese Cabinet met in emergency session ... as rival factions in ... Tripoli blasted each other with ... gunfire, rockets and mortars. Police said at least 20 people were killed in the fighting between Muslim and Christian gangs.

Financial agreement

Page 7

LONDON: It is now confidently expected in Paris that financial agreement between Bharat and Pakistan will be announced ... next week involving devaluation of the Pakistan rupee, says the Financial Editor of the Manchester Guardian, writing from Paris. De-valuation, he says, will bring the Pakistan rupee down to one shilling and eight pence or one shilling and nine pence while the Bharati rupee will remain at its present rate of one shilling and six pence.

An expert report by the International Monetary Fund will be basis of the agreement, he says. — *Dawn-Express Service*

[Meanwhile, according to an editorial note,] There appear to be too many “experts” in Paris... . Not only the world’s “highest monetary brains” have congregated there, but news agencies and newspapers also have sent their own “Financial editors”. So, speculation flows thick and fast. ...[C]hampagne also flows thick and fast. ... The Manchester Guardian “expert’s” vision ... whereby the Pakistani rupee is to go down to [shillings 1.8] ... or ... [1.9], could not have otherwise originated. ... It would seem that along with the pound sterling a lot of other things have also depreciated in the UK.



The heavy cost of defying nature

AS long as humans exist in harmony with nature, they stand to benefit from the equation. Those who prefer to defy nature, become losers. Truly, there is something drastically wrong with the mindset of those who allow encroachments on or along the path of rivers, and permit or overlook large-scale deforestation on the mountains where glaciers exist. As such, water gushes down the mountains and hills, when the snow melts and its momentum keeps increasing because of the slopes. It destroys human and animal lives, houses and just about everything that falls within its path.

As a basic regulatory function, government machinery is supposed to keep a vigilant eye on the greed of real estate mafia. It is an internationally approved norm that construction in the path of water, especially on the riverbed, is not allowed. Yet, we have been doing this over the years.

The three eastern rivers of Ravi, Sutlej and Beas are in the control of India under the Indus Waters Treaty. The riverbeds remain dry most of the time till India releases excess water from snow-melting during monsoons. When this happens, these dry riverbeds overflow and become deadly.

Encroachments, like housing societies and hotels, on riverbed and in the path of water is a criminal act. This is a cancer that must be surgically removed to serve as a deterrence. There is no justification for investing billions of taxpayers' money to build embankments to save a housing project that should never have been built.

Malik Tariq Ali
Lahore

Property tax hike

Page 7

THE residents of Karachi's cantonment areas, including Karachi Cantonment, Clifton, Malir, Faisal, Korangi Creek and Manora, are facing an increasingly inequitable burden in the form of steep property tax hikes imposed by their respective cantonment boards. This year's tax bills reflect an arbitrary increase of 15-20 per cent, with no public consultation or justification.

Property taxes are significantly lower in other parts of Karachi that are governed by the Karachi Metropolitan Corporation (KMC) and other local bodies. Citizens of all zones, cantonment or otherwise, live in the same city and use similar infrastructure, yet those under federal cantonment boards are penalised by a taxation regime that is neither balanced nor uniform.

There have been multiple court cases in the past on this matter, with at least one notable judgment directing the cantonment boards to ease the burden on residents. Yet, these legal directions seem to have been ignored in the latest round of tax assessments.

Residents feel doubly burdened — first, by the lack of uniformity in municipal services, and, second, by high, unregulated property taxes that outpace inflation and earnings. Besides, there is no clear breakdown or rationale provided for how these taxes are assessed, or used for local improvement.

The federal government, particularly the Ministry of Defence and the Directorate-General of Military Lands and Cantonments, should immediately review and rationalise the property tax structure in all cantonment areas of Karachi.

Until such a review is conducted, the recent tax increase should be suspended.

Prof Shahab Afroz Khan
Karachi

The man from Ghotki

Page 7

GROWING up in the 1990s, I was intrigued by a phrase I often saw painted on trawlers and tankers moving on roads and highways. It read something like this: 'Kafeel Bhai Ghotki — an all-round cricketer; right-arm and left-arm spin bowler'. The description never failed to attract people's curiosity.

Years later, I met the man in person. Kafeel Bhai, as he is known to one and all, was an accomplished painter of truck art in his prime. From horses to lions, and from Madam Noor Jehan to Lady Diana, he painted them all. And, of course, he never forgot to add his own 'introduction' as an ambidextrous spin bowler in local cricket.

In 1992, a French art magazine is said to have published images of his art that put Kafeel Bhai in touch with some art lovers in France, who, according to the man, even offered to sponsor his move to France, an offer he thankfully turned down.

Today, Kafeel Bhai is considered to be a folk character in and around his beloved Ghotki. Unfortunately, however, he is living his days in poverty and distress, waiting for a miracle to change his life.

Ali Sikandar Chachar
Ghotki



Inclusion or illusion?

DIVERSITY is often easy to showcase. Institutions celebrate numbers, photographs and headlines that highlight equal representation. But the reality is a bit more complex: visibility alone is not enough to guarantee respect, opportunity or empowerment.

What shifts perceptions is not mere presence, but the practice of acknowledging contributions. This difference captures the gap between diversity as a trend, and inclusivity as a culture.

Diversity, when pursued for appearances, often turns into 'tokenism'. Governments and institutions highlight statistics about women or minorities in leadership roles, but representation without respect does little to shift power.

In Pakistan, women in parliament were initially labelled 'quota members', a sign of how diversity can be dismissed. Yet over time, their role in drafting major laws on harassment and child protection showed that an inclusive culture matters more than numbers.

The takeaway is clear: diversity shines for the cameras, but inclusivity requires consistent belief in equal worth. Diversity can open doors, but inclusivity ensures people belong and thrive.

True empowerment is not about proving one's worth again and again; it is about creating a culture where people and their contributions are respected by one and all.

Tabia Khalil
Karachi

remains blocked by private dams and barriers, depriving the lake of its fresh water sources.

This injustice has negatively affected the residents of the Nammal valley. The government needs to take concrete steps to revive the lake by excavating it, removing the illegal barriers, and building more small lakes to store water, enhancing the area's beauty and generating revenue.

Muhammad Iqbal Awan
Mianwali

A neglected lake

NAMMAL Lake, located at the confluence of Mianwali, Chakwal and Khushab, is one of the most beautiful lakes in the country, but has remained largely neglected. Built in 1913, the Nammal Dam provides water to the western regions of Mianwali district that rely heavily on the lake's water.

The dam was constructed to improve groundwater levels and irrigation. However, due to lack of foresight, the natural flow of rainwater into the lake

between doctors and patients is vital. On their part, all doctors must adopt a humanist approach to their practice, remembering that patients and their families are seriously worried about the situation. Not everyone is trying to degrade them. Such understanding can make doctors more flexible in their approach.

Patients should be able to feel free to seek information and accurate guidance. People at large have to understand that not everything found online applies to them.

When both sides respect each other's role and remain positive, communication improves, anxiety is reduced, and treatment becomes more successful. A negative mind, on the other hand, will never produce a positive recovery. Trust is the real medicine that heals both body and mind.

Hani Wahid Baloch
Karachi

A tricky approach

IN today's world, many patients research their symptoms online before visiting the hospital. These patients often fall into two groups; those who are genuinely curious and eager to understand their condition, and those who unintentionally plan to challenge their doctor's expertise.

While curiosity is natural, excessive reliance on complex online terminology can create misunderstandings, strain doctor-patient relationship, and erode trust.

As stressed by psychologists, when the mind does not accept something, outcomes never have a chance to be perfect. When patients make up their minds to trust their doctor and believe that they will be treated well, this trust can help the whole recovery process. The element of trust

Woman killed as mortar shell hits Bajaur house

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

BAJAUR: A woman was killed and her daughter injured after a mortar shell fired from an unknown direction hit their house in the troubled Lowi Mamund tehsil of Bajaur district on Monday morning.

Residents and sources said the incident occurred in the Gohati Mena area when a mortar shell fired from an unspecified location fell on Niamat Khan's house, killing his wife and injuring his daughter.

"It was not immediately clear as to who fired the mortar shell or from where it was fired. However, the affected area is among those that had largely been vacated by residents on the directives of the district administration due to the ongoing operation against terrorists, the sources said.

Meanwhile, political, social activists, and local residents expressed deep sorrow over the incident and called for steps to curb such occurrences in any area of the region in future.

Man killed in Kaghan bear attack

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

MANSEHRA: A black bear killed a man in the Paras area of Kaghan Valley on Monday.

“The bear entered the populated area in search of food and attacked the man. Despite repeated requests, the wildlife department has failed to prevent wild animals from straying into villages in the area,” Mohammad Basharat, a resident, told reporters.

The victim, Fazlur Rehman, was taking his herd to nearby fields for grazing when the bear attacked him, leaving him critically injured.

He was rushed to a local health facility, where doctors pronounced him dead. His body was later handed over to the family.

Mr Basharat said residents had earlier sought the wildlife department’s help after wild animals repeatedly killed their goats and cattle, but no action was taken.

“Now a human has been killed in broad daylight. If preventive measures are not adopted, more lives may be lost in attacks by wild creatures,” he warned.

The dense alpine forests are the natural habitat of leopards, black and brown bears, which often descend onto populated areas in search of food.

According to the wildlife department, these animals mostly attack livestock, though female bears can turn aggressive if their cubs are threatened or stolen.

KP Assembly urges govt to withdraw plea about action in aid ordinance

Page 8

Forms special panel on security

By Umer Farooq

PESHAWAR: The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Assembly on Monday unanimously passed a resolution against the KP Action (in Aid of Civil Power) Ordinance, declaring it against basic human rights and urged the provincial government to withdraw a plea in its favour from the apex court.

The resolution, moved by treasury member Daud Shah in a session chaired by Speaker Babar Saleem Swati, said that if the Constitution was examined, the KP Actions (in aid of civil power) Ordinance, 2019, and Regulations, 2011, went against the basic human rights and the Peshawar High Court had already declared it so, but the provincial government appealed the verdict in the Supreme Court.

"This house recommends to the provincial government to declare implementation of the said law in KP and merged districts against basic rights and withdraw its appeal about it from the Supreme Court," the resolution read.

The KP Action (in Aid of Civil Power) Ordinance, 2019, which was issued by the provincial governor on Aug 5, 2019, is almost a reproduction of two regulations promulgated by the president in 2011 for the then Federally Administered Tribal Areas (Fata) and Provincially Administered Tribal Areas (Pata), giving legal cover to several detention centres set up during military operations in different regions.

It assigns wide-ranging powers to the authorised officers and armed forces and grants an authority to detain a suspect until the continuation of action in

aid of civil power by the armed forces.

Also, the house constituted a special committee on security. It will check and decide its terms of reference in the first meeting.

The meeting of the 30-member committee will be chaired by Speaker Babar Saleem Swati and attended by members from merged districts and those with volatile law and order situation. Some stakeholders will be in attendance on special invitation.

The security committee, formed after consensus of both treasury and opposition after the conclusion of discussion on the law and order situation in the provincial assembly, will be briefed by the relevant officials involved in operations against terrorism.

Also, the data will be shared with lawmakers. The members will discuss ways to restore peace in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

Earlier, chief whip of the ruling Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf Akbar Ayub Khan said that the treasury and opposition held a sitting for constituting a house committee on the law and order situation in the province.

"Chief Minister Ali Amin Khan Gandapur has sent a message for you to constitute a joint committee comprising all stakeholders. He will also be part of the committee and meetings will be held with people related to institutions on law and order," Mr Khan said.

Leader of the Opposition Dr Ibadullah said debate should be held. He said ToRs for the committee should be finalised and a meeting should be held for a way forward as soon as possible.

PPP member Ahmad Kundi suggested that people's representatives from terrorism-hit areas be included.

"Either the speaker or leader of the opposition should chair the committee," he said.

He said that the opposition's proposals and ToRs were ready and would be

shared with the speaker.

ANP member Nisar Baaz said the opposition had suggested formation of the committee and people had left their houses and accommodated in schools, which had an impact on the educational system in his constituency of Bajaur district.

"The XI corps commander and the police chief should be summoned to the house for an in-camera briefing over their claims about clearing two tehsils of Bajaur district as those areas await such clearance," he said.

The lawmaker said lawmakers from tribal districts should be engaged to share the ground situation.

Special assistant to the chief minister on housing Dr Amjad Ali said that the opposition leader's suggestion was discussed with the chief minister.

He said a special committee should be formed with representation from tribal districts and the other areas where military operations are ongoing.

"We want this issue to be resolved and agree to call the corps commander and police chief to the house for a briefing on the reasons for terrorism resurgence and the way-out," he said.

Mr Kundi said the federal government had to hold at least four meetings of the Council of Common Interest annually with each held after a gap of 90 days.

He said that the province could formally seek an urgent CCI meeting. The lawmaker insisted that the federal government was not fulfilling its Constitutional obligation.

"A discussion should be held in the relevant house committee to ensure a CCI meeting is held after every 90 days," he said.

Minister for law and parliamentary affairs Aftab Alam Afridi said the CCI chairman was bound to call the body's meeting but unfortunately, there were many issues including a delay in the

meeting of the National Finance Commission.

"When somebody takes the province's chief executive lightly, how do you expect them to hold a meeting on recommendations of a house committee?"

Speaker Swati observed that a house committee with members from both treasury and opposition benches holding a meeting was like parliament standing by the government.

The house passed the KP Charities Amendment Bill, 2025, and KP Legal Aid Amendment Bill, 2025. The bills were tabled by Mr Afridi.

The members also unanimously passed a resolution demanding that the health, social welfare and education departments devise a system providing free career counselling, psychological therapy and, if needed, psychiatric treatment to young people facing challenges in a remote region and that the facilities be available at UC levels and a telephone hotline be set up for suicide prevention.

The resolution moved by Fatehul Mulk Ali Nasir read that Lower and Upper Chitral districts face immense social issues, especially affecting young women and highly-educated men.

The house also passed a resolution seeking the issuance of driving licences by the police department saying the transport department lacks trained staff and technical facilities.

The resolution was moved by treasury MPA Ubaidur Rehman.

Special assistant to the chief minister Rangez Ahmad informed the house that around 0.2 million driving licences would be issued within a month and the pendency of applications would be removed.

He also said 10,000 licences would be "available" by tomorrow [Wednesday].

The chair later adjourned the session until 2pm today (Tuesday).

PHC CJ terms provision of speedy justice top priority

Page 8

First-ever ceremony held in high court to mark start of new judicial year

Bureau Report

PESHAWAR: Peshawar High Court Chief Justice SM Attique Shah said here on Monday that providing speedy justice to litigants was their top priority and they were talking drastic measures to strengthen district judiciary for provision of transparent and swift justice to people.

He highlighted the overall disposal rate in the high court and district judiciary, stating that as of July 31, the high court disposed of 23,326 cases reducing the pendency from 39,073 to 36,702.

He said that district judiciary also disposed of 52,783 cases, reducing the pendency of cases from 263,437 to 223,419, which clearly indicated significant improvement in the disposal rate of cases. However, he added that more efforts were being made to reduce the burden of cases.

PHC Chief Justice Attique Shah was addressing the first-ever judicial year opening ceremony. The ceremony was attended by senior puisne judge Justice Ijaz Anwar, judges of high court, president of PHC Bar Association Aminur Rehman Yousafzai, Additional Attorney General Sanaullah Khan, KP Advocate General Shah Faisal Uthmankhel, Vice-chairman of KP Bar Council Ahmad Farooq Khattak, chairman of KP Service Tribunal, director general and dean of KP Judicial Academy, district and sessions judge, judges of special courts and tribunals, members of legal fraternity and others.

The event marked the commencement of a new judicial tradition, aimed at reaffirming the judiciary's collective resolve to provide inexpensive and expeditious justice, to reflect on achievements of the past year, and to deliberate upon the future course of action for strengthening the justice system.

While recognising the integral role of other stakeholders including police, prosecution and prisons in the justice system, the PHC chief justice also highlighted infrastructure development, strengthening of research wing, adoption of technology, court automation, case flow management information system (CFMIS), establishment of alternate dispute resolution (ADR) courts, induction of judges including 10 additional judges in PHC and 22 new additional district and sessions judges in district judiciary, and capacity building through KP Judicial Academy.

He noted that this was the first such

ceremony in the history of PHC, signifying both a milestone and a renewal of commitment to justice. He announced the launch of a five-year strategic plan (2025-2030) for accelerated disposal of backlog cases, solarisation of courts and bar rooms, infrastructure development, induction of judges and introduction of a fully integrated e-filing system, AI-driven legal research, and decision-support tools.

"Our mission is noble and our cause is sacred: to deliver justice under all circumstances, without fear or favour, affection or ill-will," he said.

The PHC chief justice said that various committees had also been formed in the high court to resolve litigants' issues promptly. He stated that timely justice couldn't be delivered by courts alone and judicial system couldn't improve without the cooperation of bar associations and legal community.

"Additionally, we are encouraging alternative dispute resolution (ADR) system for swift resolution of cases, as this system facilitates provision of prompt justice," he said.

PHC Chief Justice Attique Shah said that under National Judicial Policy 2009, revised in 2025, discussions had been held with police, prosecution and jail authorities regarding timely submission of charge sheets and appearance of witnesses.

"Furthermore, the budget allocated for courts has been significantly increased, which includes construction of new judicial complexes, modern facilities for lawyers and establishment of bar rooms for women lawyers," he said, adding that filing of cases was being computerised according to modern requirements and litigants could easily check the status of their cases from home.

In his address, Aminur Rehman Yousafzai said that the observance of judicial year opening was a solemn tradition practiced in developed countries and in Supreme Court of Pakistan. He stressed the need for timely, independent and accessible justice.

AAG Sanaullah highlighted the role of judiciary and responsibility of law officers, urging adoption of technology in judicial reforms and greater coordination among bench, bar and government.

Ahmad Farooq Khattak appreciated measures of high court for effective case disposal and suggested use of technology, filling of judicial vacancies and improving facilitation for both courts and bar.

Shah Faisal Uthmankhel acknowledged the judiciary as guardian of rights and freedoms. He underscored the need to discourage adjournments, resist delaying tactics and avoid overburdening courts with unnecessary litigation.

PkMAP protests suicide attack on Quetta public meeting

Page 8

Dawn Report

PESHAWAR: The Pakhtunkhwa Milli Awami Party (PkMAP) on Monday staged rallies across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa against a suicide blast targeting a public meeting in Quetta on Sept 2.

The Quetta gathering was attended by PkMAP chairman Mehmood Khan Achakzai, Balochistan National Party president Sardar Akhtar Jan Mengal and senior leaders of other parties.

The Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf leaders and workers joined protest rallies on the instructions of their detained leader, Imran Khan.

In Peshawar, a protest was staged outside the Peshawar Press Club, with PkMAP leaders Haji Inamullah and Niazbeen and PTI MNA Shandana Gulzar, leader Irfan Saleem and MPA Haji Fazal Ilahi in attendance.

The speakers denounced the Quetta attack as an act against democratic values and praised Mr Achakzai as a voice for the oppressed and a symbol of constitutional resistance.

MNA Shandana said that the PkMAP chief was targeted with a suicide bomber because Imran Khan had trusted him and he was making a struggle for the constitutional supremacy in the country.

She demanded those behind attacks on political leaders be exposed.

"Some forces are trying to seize the mines and minerals in Pakhtun areas, so they're spoiling the situation to grab those natural resources," she said.

Afzal Khan Khamosh, the central leader of the Mazdoor Kisan Party, said that unfortunately, the blood of Pakhtuns was being shed through bombs, but no one was bothered about it.

"We [Pakhtuns] say that we are peaceful people, but no one listens to us," he said.

Addressing a large gathering in Swat, PkMAP provincial president Dr. Mohammad Ali said that such cowardly tactics could never silence Mehmood Achakzai or his party, according to a statement issued here on Monday.

He described the blast as an attack on the democratic voice of Pakhtun and Baloch nations.

Dr Ali called Achakzai a symbol of democracy and federalism in Pakistan.

"Bombs attacks are actually attempts to silence him," he said.

In Swabi, senior deputy chairman of PkMAP Arshad Khan termed the Quetta blast part of a conspiracy to suppress progressive voices.

He warned that if PkMAP leadership was targeted again, the party would shut down the entire province in protest.

Protest rallies were also organised in Kohat, Charsadda, Mardan and other cities of the province.

Remittances stay strong despite incentives cut

Page 9

Inflows rose 6.6pc to \$3.13bn in Aug

By Shahid Iqbal

KARACHI: Remittances sent by overseas Pakistanis have remained robust despite the rationalisation of incentives for banks and exchange companies.

According to the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), remittance inflows in the first two months of FY26 rose by 7pc, dispelling fears that a reduction in incentives would lead to a decline in remittances.

In August, remittances totalled \$3.137 billion, showing a 6.6pc year-on-year increase. However, the monthly inflows saw a slight decline of 2.4pc compared to July, when they were \$3.214bn.

While the growth in the first two months of FY26 is positive, it pales in comparison to the remarkable growth witnessed during the same period last fiscal year. Remittances surged by 44pc in 2MFY25 compared to FY24. This extraordinary growth contributed to a record annual total of \$38.3bn, which helped maintain exchange rate stability and allowed the SBP to increase its foreign reserves by \$7.8bn, reaching \$14.5bn.

The government does not expect remittance growth to match the record levels of FY25 but remains hopeful that total inflows will reach around \$40bn in FY26.

Despite these expectations, remittances from regions outside the Middle East have shown a decline. Inflows from major destinations like Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and GCC countries accounted for about 55pc of total remittance inflows during July-August FY26.

The inflows from Saudi Arabia amounted to \$1.56bn, reflecting a modest growth of just 6pc, compared to a 50.7pc increase during the same period last year. Remittances from the UAE grew by 13.8pc, down significantly from the 84.3pc growth recorded in the first two months of FY25, totalling \$1.308bn.

In contrast, inflows from other GCC countries reached \$600 million, showing a growth of 5.3pc.

Meanwhile, remittances from the UK and USA showed a decline, with the former down by 0.5pc to \$913.7 million, and the latter down by 13.7pc to \$537 million. On a positive note, remittances from the European Union (EU) continued to grow, increasing by 18pc to reach \$857 million in the first two months of FY26. Financial experts emphasise the need for remittances to remain strong throughout FY26 to maintain a current account surplus and preserve the stability of the exchange rate.

Govt urged to avoid spectrum auctions for sake of revenues

Page 9

By Kalbe Ali

ISLAMABAD: The telecom industry, along with the GSMA, has urged the government not to use spectrum auctions as a revenue-generation tool.

During a meeting on Monday, the Spectrum Advisory Committee, chaired by Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb, discussed the challenges faced by the telecom sector. Key stakeholders, including the Chairman and CEO of the Telecom Operators Association (TOA), Amir Ibrahim, and representatives from other telecom companies, were present at the meeting.

Julian Gorman, GSMA's Head of Asia-Pacific, led the global body and highlighted significant flaws in Pakistan's spectrum pol-

icy. He pointed to high reserve prices and regulatory hurdles as factors undermining the progress of the telecom sector.

Amir Ibrahim emphasised the need for a pricing and policy framework that fosters investment. "With the right reforms, we can deliver faster networks, stronger exports, and meaningful digital inclusion," he said.

The meeting was also attended by Minister for IT and Telecom, Shaza Fatima, Law Minister Senator Azam Nazeer Tarar, and senior officials from relevant ministries and regulators.

During the session, the government side noted that legal issues hindering spectrum allocation were being addressed to clear the spectrum stuck in litigation.

Gender diversity awards

Page 9

KARACHI: The Gender Diversity Awards were announced on Monday at a ceremony organised by the International Finance Corporation (IFC) and the Pakistan Business Council (PBC). The awards recognise companies that are leading the charge in creating inclusive workplaces and improving economic opportunities for women in Pakistan.

This year's top winners include Engro Fertilizers, Engro Polymer & Chemicals,

Pakistan Mobile Communications (Jazz), Habib Bank Limited (HBL), and English Biscuit Manufacturers (EBM).

The awards aim to celebrate private sector employers who have shown a strong commitment to empowering women by embedding gender diversity policies and practices. These companies have also been recognised for publicly disclosing their efforts, encouraging others to follow suit.—Staff Reporter

Equities surge past 156,000-point milestone despite flood challenges

AHL report estimates flood damage, primarily to agriculture, at \$1.4bn

By Muhammad Kashif

KARACHI: Amid ongoing economic challenges, including the aftermath of devastating floods, Pakistan's stock market extended its bullish momentum for a seventh consecutive session on Monday.

This remarkable rally saw the benchmark KSE 100 Index surpass the 156,000-point mark for the first time in the history of the Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX), driven by strong corporate earnings reports.

According to Topline Securities Ltd, the market began the week on a strong note, with the KSE 100 index reaching an all-time high of 156,199 points. Investor optimism fuelled an impressive intraday rally, as the index gained as much as 1,922 points before closing at

PAKISTAN STOCK EXCHANGE

THE TOP FIVE

GAINERS		LOSERS		LEADERS*	
Sitara Chemical	87.75	PIA Holding CoB	506.00	K-Electric	93.74
Service Industries	55.36	Unilever Foods	90.67	Bank of Punjab	71.44
Nestle Pakistan	34.61	Siemens Pakistan	36.80	Dewan Cement	63.92
Ismail Industries	29.27	Supernet Tech	27.18	First Nat'l. Equities	37.91
Reliance Cotton	21.01	S.S.Oil Mills	22.62	Pak Elektron	37.53

(Share values in rupees)

* Volume in millions of traded shares

ACTIVITY

Total listed	532
Active	482
Gainers	229
Losers	228

PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$3.68m
Companies	▲ \$5.53m
Banks	▼ \$3.07m
Mutual Funds	▲ \$1.37m
Individuals	▲ \$1.76m

INDICATORS

	Monday	Previous	Change
KSE 100-SHARE INDEX (Points)	156,087.31	154,277.19	▲ 1,810.11
KSE 30-SHARE INDEX (Points)	47,639.20	47,063.22	▲ 575.98
MARKET CAPITAL (Rs billion)	18,267.348	18,133.121	▲ 134.226
TRADING VALUE (Rs billion)	62.295	59.949	▲ 2.345

156,087 points, a rise of 1,810 points or 1.17 per cent. The rally was primarily supported by better-than-expected corporate earnings and strong liquidity from local institutional investors, propelling the index into uncharted territory.

Investor confidence remained robust, with market heavyweights attracting significant flows, further bolstering

the positive sentiment. Key contributors to the rally included Engro Holdings, Hub Power, Lucky Cement, Mari Energy, and Sui Northern Gas Pipelines, which collectively added 1,144 points to the index. On the other hand, profit-taking in stocks like United Bank, Systems Ltd, and Fauji Cement led to a 191-point dip.

A notable highlight of

the session was Engro Holdings, whose impressive earnings report sparked renewed investor interest, pushing its stock higher and contributing 405 points to the index's ascent.

Market participation remained strong, with total trading volume rising by 4.43pc to 1.12 billion shares. The total traded value also increased by 3.91pc,

reaching Rs 62.2bn. K-Electric led the volume chart, with 93.7 million shares traded.

Ali Najib, Deputy Head of Trading at Arif Habib Ltd, commented that the PSX continued its unstoppable rally, surpassing the 156,000 barrier. He highlighted that blue-chip stocks in sectors such as fertilisers, power, cement, exploration and production (E&P), and oil mar-

keting companies (OMCs) attracted fresh buying momentum. Hubco was in the spotlight after its Friday briefing revealed that BYD had already sold over 2,000 cars in six months, with more than 500 pre-orders for its Shark model. This news drove Hubco's stock up by 5.78pc, reaching Rs 197.

However, AHL Research issued a cautionary note, warning that while the economy is showing resilience, the damage caused by recent floods is estimated at Rs409bn (\$1.4bn), with agriculture bearing the brunt of the losses. Nearly three-fourths of the total damage is attributed to the agriculture sector, underscoring the vulnerability of Pakistan's economy to climate-related shocks.

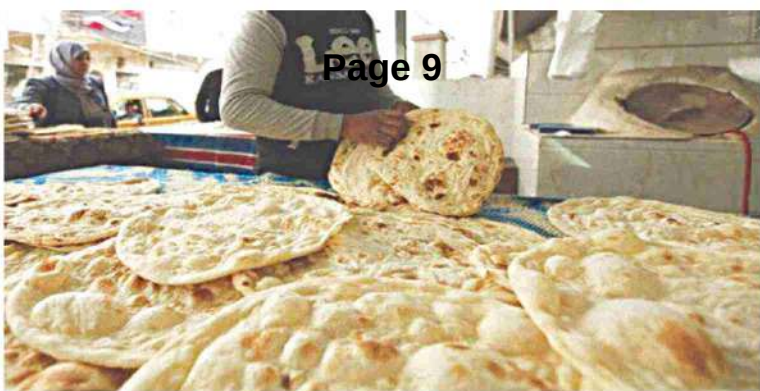
Despite these challenges, the bullish trend in the stock market shows no signs of slowing down. With momentum still strong, the PSX is expected to continue pushing for fresh highs in the coming sessions. The support base for the market has now solidified at the 154,000-point level, providing a solid foundation for further gains.

ACTIVITY

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PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$3.68m
Companies	▲ \$5.53m
Banks	▼ \$3.07m
Mutual Funds	▲ \$1.37m
Individuals	▲ \$1.76m



CONSUMERS are bearing the brunt as tandoor operators raise rates, impacting low-income groups—White Star

Flour, roti prices rise

By Aamir Shafaat Khan

KARACHI: Following a surge in sugar prices, consumers are now facing higher costs for flour and roti across various parts of Pakistan as wheat and flour prices continue to rise.

In Karachi, tandoor operators have raised the price of various roti varieties by an average of Rs2 per piece, which will mainly impact low- and middle-income groups, particularly daily wage earners and the labour class, who typically rely on eating their meals at local eateries.

The sharp rise in prices is evident in branded flour, with some millers raising the cost of a five-kilogram bag of fine flour to Rs700, up from Rs500 on Aug 1 and Rs600 on Sept 1, despite the arrival of the new wheat crop earlier this year. Retailers report that large-scale traders are likely profiting from the rise in prices, taking advantage of the higher demand for old flour stocks.

Some market analysts believe the ongoing wheat crisis is unrelated to the recent floods in Punjab and other regions, as the new wheat crop was harvested in March/April. However, hoarders, stockists, and investors are reportedly holding substantial wheat stocks, waiting for further price hikes driven by supply and demand dynamics.

Salman Mian Araieen, a member of

the All Sindh Sheermal Tandoor Roti Association, stated that tandoor operators who were previously selling naan at Rs22 and Rs23 per piece (weighing 180 grams) have now raised prices to Rs25. Additionally, the price of chapati has increased by Rs2 per piece, reaching Rs14-15, up from Rs11-12. Some tandoor owners have refrained from passing on the full impact of rising flour prices, waiting for a potential reversal in flour rates.

According to Araieen, the price of 50 kg of fine atta has risen by Rs1,900 in just a month, now costing Rs5,700 per bag, up from Rs3,800. Despite the rise in flour costs, the prices of sheermal and taftan have remained unchanged, even as sugar prices climbed to Rs200 per kg from Rs180, and the cost of a 16kg tin of ghee surged to Rs7,900 from Rs6,500 in recent months. Currently, sheermal and taftan are priced at Rs70-90 per piece, depending on weight and quality. If flour prices continue to rise, an additional Rs10 per piece may be added to these items.

Some tandoor owners are reportedly considering discontinuing the sale of Rs20 naan (weighing 140-145 grams), as the price no longer covers their costs. Araieen noted that the price of a 40kg wheat bag, which has now reached Rs3,943 (Rs9,857 per 100kg), is the highest recorded in 72 weeks, last seen in April 2024.

SECP registers 3,278 new companies in August

ISLAMABAD: The Securities and Exchange Commission of Pakistan (SECP) registered 3,278 new companies in August, raising the total number of registered companies in the country to 265,587.

Private limited companies dominated the new registrations, accounting for 59pc, followed by single-member companies at 39pc. The remaining 4pc comprised public unlisted companies, not-for-profit organisations, and limited liability partnerships.

The Information Technology and e-commerce sectors led the way with 670 new incorporations, followed by trading with 413, services with 394, and real estate development and construction with 297. Other active sectors included tourism and transport (242), food and beverages (185), education (150), mining and quarrying (77), textiles (76), pharmaceuticals (69), cosmetics and toiletries (66), marketing and advertising (65), agricultural farming and engineering (49 each), chemicals (48), and healthcare (44).—Staff Reporter

Trade deficit with ME soars 22pc

Page 9

By Mubarak Zeb Khan

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan's trade deficit with the Middle East surged by 22.38 per cent in the first month of FY26, largely driven by the rising influx of petroleum products from the region. According to data compiled by the State Bank of Pakistan, the trade deficit with the Middle East reached \$1.323 billion in July FY26, up from \$1.081bn during the same month last year.

In FY25, the deficit with the region increased by 7.37pc, rising to \$13.974bn from \$13.014bn in the previous year. The growing trade imbalance has raised concerns among policymakers, with the primary culprit being the rising import of petroleum products from the Middle East. While petroleum consumption has increased, exports to the region have only seen modest growth, concentrated in a limited number of countries.

Exports to the Middle East declined by 16.11pc in July FY26, falling to \$254.15 million from \$302.99m in the same month of the previous year. For FY25, exports to the region dropped by 1.52pc, reaching \$3.107bn, compared to \$3.155bn in FY24.

At the same time, imports from the Middle East saw an increase of 14.02pc, rising to \$1.578bn in July FY26, compared to \$1.384bn in the same period last year. In FY25, imports grew by 5.64pc, reaching \$17.081bn, up from \$16.169bn in FY24.

Exports to Saudi Arabia fell by 5.95pc, reaching \$54.02m in July FY26, down from \$57.44m in the same month last year. Imports from Saudi Arabia also declined by 7.73pc, totalling \$330.95m compared to \$358.71m in the previous year.

Exports to the UAE saw a sharp decline of 18.56pc, falling to \$176.65m in July FY26 from \$216.92m last year. However, imports from the UAE surged by 47.77pc, reaching \$816.01m, compared to \$552.22m in July FY25.

Exports to Bahrain stood at \$5.41m in July compared to \$4.85m in the corresponding period last year. Imports from Bahrain, however, saw a sharp increase, rising to \$14.01m from just \$2.64m.

Govt eyes new gas levy amid paradox of glut and rationing

Page 9

Move aimed at providing 'level playing field' for public and private sector gas suppliers

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: As the Lahore-based Sui Northern Gas Pipelines Limited (SNGPL) continues, even in summers, with unannounced rationing of natural gas amid ongoing infighting over pipeline capacity allocation to a third party, the government is expected to impose a captive gas levy on gas distribution by the power sector to ensure a level playing field for public and private sector gas suppliers.

This is despite the fact that Pakistan officially suffers a severe natural gas and LNG supply glut,

compelling the government to seek postponement of more than 170 LNG import cargos and SNGPL forcing local gas producers to shut down their fields or scale down production.

This causes substantial losses, not only to local producers like state-owned OGDCL, listed at the London Stock Exchange, but also erodes the country's foreign exchange and forces consumers to pay high fixed charges for gas they receive for only a few hours a day.

And yet, while the political leadership remains engaged in firefighting, officials in the Centre and SNGPL — along with its board of directors, businessmen and other stakeholders concerned with investment facilitation — try to navigate their interests and arguments.

None of the parties involved *Dawn* contacted — the petroleum division, the SNGPL management and the private entities — chose to speak on the record, rather passed

the buck onto other parties.

At the same time, SNGPL has instructed local gas fields which produce cheaper gas, to shut down or reduce output to absorb expensive LNG purchased under binding international contracts. More than 300 million cubic feet per day (mmcf) of local gas production has been curtailed.

Unannounced rationing

While producers are forced to limit supply, SNGPL has begun unannounced rationing for residential and commercial customers, providing gas for only two to three hours during breakfast, lunch and dinner.

This follows a government decision to double fixed monthly charges effective July 1, 2025. Consequently, gas consumption of around Rs450 now results in a total bill near Rs 2,500, after fixed charges and taxes are added.

The production cuts have created

cash flow problems for local producers like OGDCL, GHPL and others including a few in the private sector, hampering their domestic and international exploration activities.

The country's largest producer, OGDCL, has publicly deplored the situation.

"The less gas intake by SNGPL from Qadirpur, Nashpa, Chanda, Dhok Hussain, Mela, Bettani, Pirkoh, Togh and Loti fields and TAL owing to SNGPL system constraints and by UPL from Uch fields due to less demand from power purchaser adversely impacted daily net production by 1,148 barrels of crude oil, 76 MMcf of gas and 55 tons of LPG," the company stated in a report to its board of directors a few months ago.

"During the nine months ending March 31, 2025, OGDCL registered Sales Revenue of Rs 310.907 billion (against Rs348.164 billion of same period of previous year)," the report added. "The Company's Sales

declined primarily due to forced production curtailment accompanied with reduction in average basket price of crude oil."

With the energy sector's circular debt exceeding Rs4.6 trillion, the government had allowed local producers to sell some of their gas to third parties to improve their cash flow.

Under such arrangement, some producers like MOL-Pakistan and Petroleum Exploration Limited were allowed by petroleum division to sell their output from Razgir and Zahra North field and some others to third parties.

However, SNGPL resisted an arrangement for the Razgir field, arguing it created "a market distortion".

The company noted that a Rs791 per unit captive levy, imposed on its industrial customers under IMF instructions, did not apply to third-party suppliers, prompting its customers to switch to cheaper private gas.

Despite this resistance, SNGPL's board of directors approved the pipeline capacity allocation for the Razgir gas to a third party. While SNGPL management later denied any such approval, records seen by *Dawn* indicate that at least nine of the 11 board members signed the decision.

In response to the infighting, the Ministry of Law has now ruled the captive power levy applies to all consumers of LNG or local gas, whether supplied by public or private entities.

To resolve the issue, the ministry ruled that while the sale of gas from producers to suppliers is deregulated, the subsequent sale from suppliers to CPPs is not.

The ministry determined that the price has to be determined by Ogra under section 8(6), read with sections 43A and 43B of the Ogra Ordinance for the purpose of collection of levy under the Levy Act of 2025.

Rules of war ‘being shredded’ worldwide: Turk

Page 10

GENEVA: The United Nations human rights chief warned on Monday that international law and the rules of war — the foundation of peace and global order — are being ripped up.

In his opening address to the United Nations Human Rights Council's 60th session, Volker Turk warned that “disturbing trends that undercut our rights are gaining ground across the world”.

He condemned a “troubling erosion of international law”, warning that “around the world, the long-established rules of war are being shredded, with virtually no accountability”.

He pointed to a blatant disregard for international law in conflicts, including Russia's war in Ukraine, the civil war in Sudan and the devastating war Israel is waging on Gaza.

Turk also voiced alarm at a broader “glorification of violence”.

Speaking just days after China hosted a massive military parade and after US President

Donald Trump ordered the Department of Defence to be renamed the Department of War, Turk lamented that “pro-war propaganda is everywhere, from military parades to ramped up rhetoric”. “Sadly, there are no Peace parades or Ministries of Peace”.

The UN rights chief stressed that international law is “the foundation of peace, our global order, and our daily lives, from trade rules to the global internet, to our fundamental rights”.

“But several governments are disregarding, disrespecting and disengaging from it,” he said, cautioning that “when states ignore violations of the law, they become normalised”. Without naming countries, Turk also warned that “some states are becoming an extension of their ruler's personal power”.

At the same time, he condemned “the retreat by some states from multilateral frameworks, institutions and international agreements”.

—AFP

Award ceremony for Hanks cancelled; **Page 10** Trump hails move

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump cheered on Monday after a West Point military academy ceremony honouring *Saving Private Ryan* star and outspoken critic Tom Hanks was cancelled.

The multiple Oscar-winning actor, who was also an executive producer for several acclaimed miniseries about World War II, was meant to be hosted by the academy's alumni association later this month.

However, news emerged over the weekend that this had been abruptly scrapped.

Trump, who has overseen a purge of perceived opponents across civil society and the government — including inside the US military — said he was pleased.

“Our great West Point (getting greater all the time!) has smartly cancelled the Award Ceremony for actor Tom Hanks. Important move!” Trump posted on his *Truth Social* platform.

“We don’t need destructive, WOKE recipients getting our cherished American Awards!!!” the president wrote, in an apparent reference to Hanks Democratic political leanings.

Tom Hanks was due to receive the prestigious Sylvanus Thayer Award from the West Point Association of Graduates on Sept 25.

According to *The Washington Post*, an email from the alumni association announcing the change did not specify whether Hanks would still receive the award without the ceremony.—AFP

Trump fails to get \$83m verdict overturned

US president was found by jury liable for sexual abuse of *Elle* magazine columnist

NEW YORK: A federal appeals court on Monday refused to throw out an \$83.3 million jury verdict against US President Donald Trump for damaging the reputation of the writer E. Jean Carroll in 2019 when he denied her rape claim.

The 2nd US Circuit Court of Appeals in Manhattan rejected Trump's argument that the January 2024 verdict should be overturned because he deserved presidential immunity from Carroll's lawsuit.

The 2nd Circuit on June 13 upheld Carroll's separate \$5 million jury verdict against Trump in May 2023. That jury had found Trump liable for sexual abuse and defamation, but not for rape. Both verdicts were among a slew of legal woes Trump, a Republican, faced after leaving the White House in 2021.

Trump has denied all wrongdoing, and on the campaign trail portrayed his courtroom battles as part of a Democratic-led plot to harm his ultimately successful 2024 campaign.

Now serving a second term as president, Trump is continuing to appeal unfavorable legal judgments, including his criminal con-

viction for falsifying business records to cover up a sex scandal and a judge's finding that he was liable for fraud in a civil case over his family company's business practices.

Reasonable verdict

In its unanimous opinion, a three-judge panel of the 2nd Circuit said that the \$83.3 million verdict was reasonable "in light of the extraordinary and egregious facts of this case."

In a statement on Monday, Trump's legal team said, "President Trump will keep winning against Liberal Lawfare, as he is focusing on his mission to Make America Great Again. Carroll, 81, a former *Elle* magazine columnist, accused Trump of attacking her around 1996 in a Bergdorf Goodman department store dressing room.

Trump first denied her claim in June 2019, telling a reporter that Carroll was "not my type" and had concocted the story to sell her memoir "What Do We Need Men For?" He essentially repeated his comments in an Oct 2022 Truth Social post, leading to the \$5 million verdict, though the jury did not find that Trump had raped Carroll.

The \$83.3 million award comprised \$18.3 million of damages for emotional and reputational harm, and \$65 million of punitive damages. The judges noted that Trump's attacks on Carroll ramped

up as the trial approached.

"The conduct here supports a significant punitive damages award," the court wrote. "It involved malice and deceit, caused severe emotional injury, and continued over at least a five-year period."

Tom Hanks award

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BRICS leaders denounce protectionism, tariff ‘blackmail’

Page 10

Xi Jinping calls for building open global economy, sharing opportunities and achieving win-win results through fairness

BRASILIA: Leaders of the 11-member BRICS bloc railed against economic protectionism and “tariff blackmail” during a virtual meeting on Monday held amid a damaging trade war with US President Donald Trump.

The group of emerging economies met via videoconference at the initiative of Brazil’s President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, whose office said it was necessary to address the “intensification of unilateral measures” in the world.

The BRICS represents nearly 40 per cent of global GDP and almost half of the world’s population.

Several of its members are among those most affected by what Lula referred to Monday as “tariff blackmail” and “unjustified and illegal” trade practices.

Addressing his colleagues, Chinese President Xi Jinping called for the upholding of “the multilateral trading system with the World Trade Organisation at its core” and for rejection of “all forms of protectionism.”

Brazil’s exports to the United States plunged 18.5 per cent year-on-year in August after Trump slapped his highest level of trade tariff — 50pc — on a range of goods from Latin America’s biggest economy.

Trump is punishing Brazil for what he calls a “witch hunt” against his ally, former president Jair Bolsonaro who is on trial for allegedly plotting a coup to take power back from Lula after losing the 2022 elections. A verdict in the trial is expected this week.

“Tariff blackmail is being normalised as an instrument to conquer markets and interfere in domestic affairs,” Lula said.

‘Great hardships’

Washington also imposed tariffs of up to 50pc on Indian imports, accusing New Delhi of fueling Moscow’s deadly attacks on Ukraine by purchasing Russian oil.

Russian President Vladimir Putin also took part in the virtual meeting, just days after meeting Xi, North Korea’s Kim Yong Un and India’s Narendra Modi in China where regional leaders slammed “bullying behavior” in a veiled reference to Trump’s United States.

South Africa for its part, was hit with a 30 percent tariff — the highest in sub-Saharan Africa — amid soaring tensions with Washington over a range of domestic and international policies. Trump has said he would not attend the G20 summit in South Africa later this year.

South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, in a prepared speech, said “unilateral tariff actions are contributing to an increasingly protectionist environment which poses great hardships and danger for the countries of the Global South.”

In July, Trump lashed out at the BRICS and threatened its members with additional tariffs after they voiced concern that his trade war was putting the global economy at risk.

“No matter how the international situation changes, we must remain steadfast in promoting the building of an open global economy, sharing opportunities and achieving win-win results through openness,” Xi reiterated.

Other BRICS members are Indonesia, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. —AFP

Global warming linked to consumption of sugary drinks, ice cream

Page 10

PARIS: People consuming more sugary drinks and ice cream on warmer days, particularly those with less money could pose a growing threat to health as climate change drives up temperatures, new research warned on Monday.

Sugar is a major contributor to serious health problems such as obesity, diabetes and heart disease, yet consumption of the sweet additive has surged across the world in recent decades.

Hotter days could be one factor nudging people to grab cooling sugary drinks like

soda and juice — or a few scoops of ice cream, according to a study in the journal *Nature Climate Change*.

“Your environment definitely shapes what you eat and how you eat, and climate change is part of it — it might have an adverse influence on your health,” study co-author Duo Chan of the University of Southampton said.

The team of UK-US researchers analysed data about the food bought by households in the United States between 2004 and 2019, then compared the purchases to the weather

and other climate factors.

For every extra degree of Celsius within 12-30C, people consumed 0.70 grams of extra sugar a day, the modelling showed. People with lower incomes or less education tended to be most affected.

Diets already altering

Under “worst case” climate scenarios, the most disadvantaged groups could eat or drink as much as five extra grams of sugar daily by the end of the century, lead study author Pan He of Cardiff University said.

The American Heart Association’s daily recommendation for men is no more than 36 grams of added sugar — around nine teaspoons’ worth — and 24 grams for women. One can of soda contains around 40 grams of sugar.

Most Americans consume two to three times the recommended amount, the association says.

The increase in sugar consumption seen in the study levelled off when temperatures tipped over 30C. Chen guessed this was because people had already changed their

diet by that time.

Duo said it might be “even worse news” that people were already altering their diets at lower, rather than extreme, temperatures.

The modelling also found that people bought fewer baked goods on hot days — likely because they were choosing ice cream or other frozen desserts instead.

An unhealthy diet is one of the four main risk factors for diseases that are responsible for more than 70 percent of all deaths worldwide, according to the World Health Organisation.—AFP



ARCHAEOLOGISTS work on Albania's first discovered "monumental tomb", which they suggest may be a mausoleum dated to the Roman period.—Reuters

Wealthy ancient Roman's tomb discovered in Albania

STRIKCAN: Archaeologists in Albania have discovered a large Roman burial chamber dating from the third to fourth century AD, the first of its kind found in the Balkan country that was once part of the Roman Empire.

Tipped off by locals who had noticed some unusual stones on a plateau near the North Macedonia border, staff from the Institute of Archaeology began excavating in early August and found the underground structure whose large limestone slabs were inscribed with Greek lettering.

"The inscription tells us that the person buried here was named Gelliano, a name typical of the Roman period. We are uncertain about the identity of the second individual, but it is likely a family member," said Erikson Nikolli, the project's lead archaeologist.

The tomb, which measures nine metres by six metres (29 ft by 19 ft), is the first discovery in Albania of what the experts believe to be a wealthy person's resting place, grander than other burial sites found in the area.

Local authorities in Albania, where

tourism is booming, are already planning to develop the site into a tourist attraction, while residents flocked to the area upon hearing the news of the discovery. Last week, Nikolli's team used brushes to reveal the intricately carved edges of the tomb's white roof stone and walls.

"We also uncovered a piece of fabric embroidered with gold thread, which confirms our belief that we are dealing with a member of the upper class." Other findings include glass plates and knives.

Nikolli said that the tomb had been looted at least twice once in antiquity and later when heavy machinery was used to move a massive rock on top of the chamber.

He explained that the occupants name was inscribed in Greek letters but carried a Latin meaning, while a second inscription indicates that the tomb was dedicated to the god Jupiter.

Experts have yet to decipher additional inscriptions on stones found nearby, which are believed to have belonged to another monument now surrounded by cornfields and a quarry.—Reuters

Swollen rivers continue to threaten Multan

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along the embankment to relocate immediately. The PPP leader said water would be diverted towards Sher Shah, Gagra Kachhor, Mouza Hamar and other adjacent areas to break the flood force and avoid further damage.

Meanwhile, floodwaters that had entered Jalalpur Pirwala on Sunday submerged more localities in the district, including Alipur tehsil. Due to a backwater effect that was preventing the Chenab from falling into the Indus, the water had started flowing upstream of Panjnad.

The water first entered Panjnad Headworks' downstream settlements Makhani Bela, Azmatpur, Bait Mullanwali, Bait Nabi Shah, Paka Naich, Bazwala, Lati Marri, Bait Burraha, Kundrala, and Bait Channa, and later flooded upstream areas of Ghalwan-I and Dammar Wala Janobi. The authorities relocated thousands of people to save them from flooding.

Separately, Prime Minister

Shehbaz Sharif constituted a committee led by Minister for Planning Ahsan Iqbal for the completion of the damage and need assessment report of the ongoing floods within two weeks.

Flood threat

Addressing a press conference in Multan, Provincial Disaster Management Authority Director General Irfan Ali Kathia said Jalalpur Pirwala was still facing the flood threat. He said that the first flood was moving out slowly and the water was not receding, while another surge from Head Trimmu was on its way towards Multan. He said that the pressure would increase on Head Muhammadwala and the Sher Shah dyke in the next 24 hours. He said 63 people lost their lives and rescue boats had made 27,000 trips in Multan, adding that 4300 villages in 26 districts were affected due to the Ravi, Sutlej and Chenab floods.

Multan Commissioner Aamir Kareem Khan said 4,000 people were evacuated and shifted to safer places in Jalalpur Pirwala.

Punjab Relief Commissioner

Nabil Javaid said 4,199 million people from 4,300 villages were affected due to the flooding in the eastern rivers. He said that 2,147 million people, who were trapped in the floods, had been relocated to safer locations and 412 relief and 492 medical camps were established in the flood-affected districts.

The commissioner further shared the water situation of different dams, including Mangla Dam was 88 per cent full while Tarbela Dam was 100pc full. According to the commissioner, India's Bhakra Dam on the River Sutlej was 90pc full, Pong Dam was 99pc full, while Thein Dam was 97pc full.

Earlier, the PDMA released a high-level flood alert for the Sutlej River, following an official advisory from the Indian High Commission regarding the rising water flow. According to the alert, the river was experiencing a high flood level at the Harike and Ferozepur downstream points in India, indicating that water levels were expected to rise further within Pakistan. Ganda Singh Wala Headworks

on the Sutlej would continue to be in an "exceptionally high" flood. Besides riverine floods, Punjab's urban centres also faced urban flooding. Lahore recorded a heavy rainfall in several of its areas, with some localities, including Jail Road, receiving more than 100mm of rain on Monday. Meanwhile, torrential downpour in Faisalabad broke a 30-year record for the city.

Flowing backwards

As of Monday night, the floodwaters were not receding as the Indus River was pushing back the water from the Sutlej, Chenab, and Ravi rivers. Due to this backwater effect, the operational capacity of the Panjnad Headworks had also reduced, according to a PDMA official.

Despite a steady flow of over 524,000 cusecs at Panjnad, the water was flowing upstream. Panjnad had recorded a flow of 609,664 cusecs till 12:30am and the water receded to 524,762 cusecs by 3:30 pm.

Just like the Indus, the Chenab is pushing back Ravi waters, a phenomenon that has previously

led to a perilous rise in pressure at the Sidhnai Barrage on the Ravi River. For the past few days, flows had remained dangerously steady at over 135,000 cusecs despite falling inflows from the upstream Balloki. To avert a catastrophic breach at Sidhnai, the government had to make a breach at the Mai Sufara embankment to save the barrage.

In a second major emergency operation, a controlled breach was made on the Sutlej River near Jalalpur Pirwala on Sunday night to divert water towards the Vehari district.

RYK capsized

Three people were killed while at least 8-10 people, mostly children, were missing after a boat capsized in the Chenab floodwater in the Noorwala area of tehsil Liaquatpur.

Reports said that a boat carrying almost 28 people capsized in Mouza Noorwala located in the riverbed area of the Chenab.

Irfanul Haq in Rahim Yar Khan contributed to this report

West Bank fears reprisals

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the territory — Qatana, Biddu, Beit Inan and Beit Duqu — and conducted raids there.

The Israeli military said it had reinforced its forces in the wider Jerusalem area and was conducting a wide-ranging search for what it described as “accomplices” in the shooting.

Palestinians in the West Bank are preparing themselves to face collective punishment from Israel in retaliation for the attack, a Palestinian journalist said.

According to an Al Jazeera journalist, Israeli authorities said the two perpetrators came from an area in the occupied West Bank that is just west of East Jerusalem.

They claimed the two worked in tandem; both gunmen boarded a bus – witnesses say one of them was dressed as a ticket inspector – and opened fire.

Israeli officials are now trying to wrap their heads around how exactly this happened, saying that they haven’t seen something like this happen in years, saying that the last shooting like this in greater Jerusalem was back in November 2023, Al Jazeera reported.

Israel’s far-right Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich blamed the attack on the Palestinian Authority, which he claimed “raises and educates its children to murder Jews”. But the Palestinian presidency in Ramallah said it “firmly rejected and condemned any targeting of Palestinian and Israeli civilians,” the official Palestinian news agency Wafa reported.

The PA is a civilian ruling authority in areas of the West Bank, where about three million Palestinians live – as well as around half a million Israelis occupying settlements considered illegal under international law.



JILL Rogers (right), a senior police official, arrives at a roadblock where the shootout occurred near the town of Piopio.—AFP

Fugitive father killed in shootout with New Zealand police

PIOPIO: A New Zealand father who spent nearly four years on the run with his children was killed in a police shootout on Monday, authorities said.

Tom Phillips, who absconded with his three children in December 2021 after a row with his former partner, was shot dead in the rolling hill country of the North Island's Waikato region.

Phillips' case captivated the country, particularly in the Waikato area and the town of Marokopa where he was suspected of hiding.

The family eluded capture despite several sightings, including CCTV apparently showing Phillips and a child breaking into a store last month.

But on Monday, police said Phillips had been killed after shooting an officer in the head and shoulder with a high-powered rifle after police were called to a potential burglary.

The officer who was shot was airlifted to hospital and was undergoing surgery, New Zealand Police Acting Deputy Commissioner Jill Rogers said. Rogers described the wound as "survivable", but critical.

Images of the scene taken by the *Waikato Times* show Phillips in the middle of the road, with a rifle in a ditch metres away. Several bullet holes can be seen in the police vehicles.

One of Phillips' children was with him during Monday's shooting and was taken into custody. The other two siblings were found at about 4.30pm after a full day's search at a remote campsite in the bush.

"To know the children are safe, and now receiving care after nearly four years, is an absolute relief," Rogers said. All three children, believed to be 9, 10 and 12, were unhurt.

Rogers said they were found on their own and it was unclear if they had

been told about their father's death. About 50 police officers, some of them armed, were involved in the search.

Deadly confrontation

Two police officers said that authorities had long feared the Phillips case would end in a shootout.

"We were always worried it could end in a deadly confrontation," one of the officers with knowledge of the case, who was not authorised to speak to the media, said.

Police believed Phillips had several people helping him evade capture, providing food and accommodation since he fled.

They received sporadic reports as to the health of the children and decided against a full-on search for the family so as not to threaten their safety.

In recent weeks they believed the support network may have crumbled, leading to more brazen burglaries.

"If you went to Marokopa, half the town seemed to support him and half the town thought he was a criminal," an officer said.

"But more recently his support seemed to be running thin." Since fleeing in 2021, police suspected Phillips of committing several crimes and charged him with aggravated robbery, aggravated wounding and unlawful possession of a firearm. The mother of the three children, known as Cat, said she was relieved the ordeal had ended.

"They have been dearly missed every day for nearly four years, and we are looking forward to welcoming them home with love and care," she told national broadcaster RNZ.

"At the same time, we are saddened by how events unfolded today." She asked for the family's privacy to be respected as the children reintegrate into a "stable and loving environment" after "a long and difficult journey".—AFP

Heathrow terminal check-in evacuated over ‘incident’

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LONDON: Heathrow's Terminal 4's check-in area was “closed and evacuated” on Monday evening as emergency services responded to an “incident”, the airport's operator said on social media.

The UK's main international airport, one of the world's busiest air hubs, told passengers not to travel to the terminal.

The London Fire Brigade said its firefighters were responding to a “possible hazardous materials incident”, according to a statement reported by the BBC.

“Specialist crews have been deployed to carry out an assessment of the scene, and part of the airport has been evacuated as a precaution whilst firefighters respond,” the fire brigade said.

The UK's National Rail network said in a statement on X that its trains were “unable to call” at the terminal, southwest of London, as a result.

Heathrow said that “all other terminals are operating as normal”.—AFP

Over 1,500 film industry figures call for boycott of Israeli cinema bodies

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Signatories pledge to do everything they can to address complicity in unrelenting horror in Gaza

LONDON: More than 1,500 film industry figures including actors Olivia Colman and Mark Ruffalo vowed to boycott Israeli cinema bodies they said were “implicated in genocide” in Gaza, in an open letter published on Monday.

“We pledge not to screen films, appear at or otherwise work with Israeli film institutions — including festivals, cinemas, broadcasters and production companies — that are implicated in genocide and apartheid against the Palestinian

people,” read the letter published in *The Guardian* newspaper.

The signatories included British stars Aimee Lou Wood, Josh O’Connor and Tilda Swinton, American actors Ayo Edebiri and Cynthia Nixon, and filmmakers Ken Loach and Yorgos Lanthimos.

The letter, organised by the group Film Workers for Palestine, said it was inspired by filmmakers who had refused to screen their work in apartheid South Africa.

“In this urgent moment of crisis, where many of our governments are enabling the carnage in Gaza, we must do everything we can to address complicity in that unrelenting horror,” the letter read.

The institutions to be boycotted would

include any involved in “whitewashing or justifying genocide and apartheid”, or those which partnered with the Israeli government.

The group behind the letter cited the Jerusalem Film Festival and the Docaviv documentary film festival, which “continue to partner with the Israeli government”.

“The vast majority of Israeli film production and distribution companies, sales agents, cinemas and other film institutions have never endorsed the full, internationally recognised rights of the Palestinian people,” according to a FAQ document accompanying the letter.

The pledge does not specifically target Israeli individuals. Instead the document said the “refusal takes aim at institutional complicity, not identity”, adding

that “a few Israeli film entities are not complicit”.

Several open letters signed by prominent figures from the worlds of cinema, music and literature have been published as pressure grows on the Israeli government to end the devastating, nearly two-year war in Gaza and urgently address the humanitarian crisis.

An Italian filmmakers’ collective, Venice4Palestine, urged the city’s film festival in August to take a stand, with their letter gathering 2,000 signatures, including Oscar-winning director Guillermo del Toro.

Israel’s relentless offensive in Gaza has killed at least 64,522 people, mostly women and children, according to the health ministry in the Hamas-run territory.—AFP



BERN: Swiss doctors sit outside the parliament building at the start of their hunger strike over Gaza, calling on their government to apply targeted sanctions on Israel over its violations of international law and to recognise a Palestinian state.—Reuters

Spain bans ships, planes carrying weapons for Israel

MADRID: Spain on Monday banned ships and aircraft carrying weapons to Israel from calling at Spanish ports or entering its airspace due to Israel's military offensive in Gaza, measures the Israeli foreign minister denounced as anti-semitic.

Spain, which recognised a Palestinian state in May 2024 and has been a vocal critic of Israel's actions in the Gaza Strip, responded to Gideon Sa'ar's comments by summoning its ambassador in Tel Aviv back for consultations.

On top of the ban on ships and aircraft delivering weapons or military-grade jet fuel to Israel, Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez's government said it would not allow anyone who has participated directly in

"genocide" in Gaza to enter Spain.

Sa'ar accused Sanchez of using the measures in an attempt to divert attention from domestic corruption scandals, and announced an entry ban on Sanchez's deputy, Yolanda Diaz, and Youth Minister Sira Rego. Both belong to hard-left party Sumar, the junior partner in Sanchez's coalition government.

Spain's Foreign Ministry said Israel's entry ban was unacceptable, adding that Sanchez's measures were in line with public sentiment in Spain and reflected Madrid's support for peace, human rights and international law.

It said Spain was committed to fighting antisemitism, pointing to the granting of Spanish citizenship to 72,000 Sephardic Jews —

descendants of those expelled from the Iberian Peninsula in the 15th century.

In a separate statement, the ministry said Spain strongly condemned Monday's "terrorist act in East Jerusalem", in which Palestinian gunmen opened fire at a bus stop, killing six people, including a Spanish national living in Israel.

New low in ties

The spat marks a new low in relations over the devastating Israeli offensive in the Palestinian territory. Sanchez said the nine measures aimed to "stop the genocide in Gaza, pursue its perpetrators and support the Palestinian population".—Agencies

Trump's alleged birthday note to Epstein released

WASHINGTON: A lewd note allegedly from Donald Trump wishing late sex offender Jeffrey Epstein happy birthday in 2003 — and alluding to their “wonderful secret” — was released on Monday by Democratic lawmakers, after the US president denied it existed.

Democrats on the US House Oversight Committee, which is probing the handling of a crim-

inal investigation into the disgraced financier, published the letter on social media after it was delivered by Epstein's estate.

The note is situated on the sketched outline of a nude woman, and was allegedly part of a book compiled of letters from Epstein's friends by his associate Ghislaine Maxwell, for the financier's fiftieth birthday. —AFP

Four decades of dissent resumes despite Trump's 'take it down' order

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Organisers of White House Peace Vigil remain defiant, vow to stave off legal challenges

By Anwar Iqbal

WASHINGTON: Going back to the White House Peace Vigil is like stepping into another era. For decades, it has been a near-permanent presence in Lafayette Square, directly across from the White House, persistent in its call for world peace.

Visitors from around the globe have encountered the ubiquitously small tent, with its handmade banners, which has persisted through rain, snow, and the summer heat — even on Christmas Day and the Fourth of July. But where past presidents respected its presence, the Donald Trump administration has taken a different approach, aiming to “take it down”.

Last week, at a White House press briefing, someone described the

vigil as an “eyesore” and asked President Trump about its presence. Trump bristled at the mention and interrupted: “I didn’t know that. Take it down. Take it down today, right now.”

Hours later, US Park Police dismantled the tent and banners, saying the action was part of a wider campaign to clear encampments in the capital. The White House defended the removal, calling the vigil a “hazard to those visiting the White House and the surrounding areas.”

Supporters of the protest reject that reasoning, pointing out that the vigil has complied with federal park rules for more than four decades. But by Sunday night, only hours after police had cleared the square again that morning, the vigil was already back. The post had been reassembled, its red umbrella stretched tight against the evening breeze, and the familiar signs once more faced the White House.

Passersby paused to read the weathered placards calling for peace and an end to war. Tourists lingered with cameras, while com-



A VIEW of protest outside the White House.—Photo by the writer

muters slowed to glance at the scene.

Origin story

The vigil's origins date back to June 1981, when activist William Thomas first began his demonstration across from the White House to advocate for nuclear disarmament and world peace. Soon after, Concepción Picciotto joined him,

eventually becoming the face of the protest.

In the years after the Sept 11 attacks, Picciotto — the vigil's most enduring presence — had explained the protest's mission thus. “We condemn terrorism as strongly as any patriotic American... but we are also against America invading Afghanistan because that too would be a mistake.”

She maintained her daily watch for more than 35 years until her death in 2016, becoming a symbol of solitary defiance. Her successor, Philipos Melaku-Bello, has carried the vigil forward since then. Talking to *Dawn*, he said the activists are preparing a legal battle to prevent the vigil's removal.

“What we are doing is within our rights and is legal, so there's no justification for removing it,” he said. “We have supporters all across the globe, and scores of lawmakers have offered to represent us in court.”

Not everyone has embraced the vigil's persistence, however. Rep. Jeff Van Drew (R-NJ) urged its removal, citing safety concerns and describing it as a blight on a historic space.

Trump's order also aligns with his broader push to clear homeless encampments ahead of the nation's 250th anniversary in 2026.

Yet civil liberties advocates and local leaders have defended the vigil, noting its compliance with the First Amendment. Del. Eleanor Holmes Norton (D-DC.) has repeatedly drawn inspiration from its mes-

sage, arguing that funding for nuclear weapons should instead go to housing, healthcare, and climate programs.

“The First Amendment protects peaceful protests, even when they're seen as unsightly or inconvenient,” she said. “If Representative Van Drew's claim that the vigil creates public safety hazards were valid, it would have been removed long ago.”

Activists also insist the vigil is not a mere ‘homeless camp’. “An encampment is where homeless people live,” Melaku-Bello explained. “As you can see, we don't have beds here. We have signs — defending the right to freedom of speech and freedom of expression and condemning wars in Gaza and Iran,” he told *Dawn*.

Maintaining the vigil requires constant staffing, a legal strategy designed to keep it within the boundaries of federal rules on overnight protests. Volunteers rotate shifts to ensure someone is always present, and Melaku-Bello himself often spends more than 100 hours a week on site.

19 protesting social media ban, corruption killed in Nepal

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UN demands swift, transparent probe into the killings

KATHMANDU: Unrest killed at least 19 people in Nepal on Monday, authorities said, as police in the capital fired tear gas and rubber bullets at protesters trying to storm parliament in anger at a social media shutdown and corruption, prompting the United Nations to demand a swift and transparent investigation into the incident.

"We are shocked by the killings and injury of protesters in Nepal today and urge a prompt and transparent investigation," UN rights office spokeswoman Ravina Shamdasani said in a statement.

Some of the mainly youth protesters forced their way into the parliament complex in Kathmandu by breaking through a barricade, a local official said, setting fire to an ambulance and hurling objects at lines of riot police guarding the legislature.

"The police have been firing

indiscriminately," one protester told the ANI news agency. "(They) fired bullets which missed me but hit a friend who was standing behind me. He was hit in the hand."

More than 100 people, including 28 police personnel, were receiving medical treatment for their injuries, police officer Shekhar Khanal told *Reuters*. Protesters were ferrying the injured to hospital on motorcycles.

Another two people were killed when protests in the eastern city of Itahari turned violent, police said.

Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli called an emergency cabinet meeting to discuss the unrest, which erupted after thousands of young people, including many wearing their school or college uniforms, took to the streets earlier on Monday.

Many carried flags and placards with slogans such as "Shut down corruption and not social media", "Unban social media", and "Youths against corruption", as they marched through Kathmandu.

Organisers of the protests, which spread to other cities in the Himalayan country, have called

them "demonstrations by Gen Z". They say the protests reflect young people's widespread frustration with government action to tackle corruption and boost economic opportunities. "This is the protest by the new generation in Nepal," another protester told ANI.

A government decision to block access to several social media platforms, including Facebook, last week has fuelled anger among the young. About 90 per cent of Nepal's 30 million people use the internet.

Officials said they imposed the ban because platforms had failed to register with authorities in a crackdown on misuse, including false social media accounts used to spread hate speech and fake news, and commit fraud.

Batons and rubber bullets

Police had orders to use water cannons, batons and rubber bullets to control the crowd and the army was deployed in the parliament area to bolster law enforcement officers, Muktiram Rijal, a spokesperson for the Kathmandu district office, told *Reuters*.—Agencies

Afghan quake survivors ‘refusing to return home’

MASUD: Haunted by the fear that aftershocks could bring rocks crashing down from the mountains, the survivors of Afghan earthquakes vowed not to return to destroyed villages but camp in fields and on riverbanks instead, even without tents to keep off the rain.

“We have no shelter, not even a tent,” said 67-year-old farmer Adam Khan, leaning on a stick outside his ruined home in the village of Masud in Afghanistan’s eastern province of Kunar, devastated last week by earthquakes and subsequent aftershocks.

“It rained last night, we had no place to take cover,” he added. “Our biggest fear is the big rocks that could come down at any moment.”

Aid groups sped in food and supplies by helicopter, but survivors say help is patchy and slow.

Families cluster in makeshift camps dotting the area. In the village of Shaheedan, farmer Shamsur-Rahman, 40, said he lost six relatives and fled with his family of nine. Now they sit in the open beside a road, flanked by their few possessions.

“The tents they gave us cannot even accommodate our children,” he said. “On the way down from the mountain, I had no shoes for my son, so I shared mine with him in turns as we walked down.”

For some, the displacement looks set to be permanent. In the harsh glare of the sun Gul Ahmad, 51, stood beside his relatives, the women of his family crouched in the shade of a wall as their pop-up tents flapped in the dust nearby.

“Even if there is no earthquake, a simple rainfall could bring rocks crashing down on us,” he said. “We will not go back. The government must provide us a place.”

Without sufficient shelter, sanitation and food, the trauma will spread disease and poverty in one of the world’s poorest and most quake-prone nations, international aid agencies say.

Some of the worst affected are children. Twelve-year-old Sadiq was pulled out alive after being trapped for 11 hours under rubble, in which his grandmother and a cousin were killed beside him.

“I thought I would die,” he said, sitting quietly on a rope bed as cousins and uncles milled around the family’s shelter. “It felt like doomsday.”

Female aid workers

The World Health Organisation has asked Taliban authorities to lift restrictions on Afghan female aid workers, allowing them to travel without male guardians and help women struggling to access care after a powerful earthquake killed 2,200 people in eastern Afghanistan. —Reuters

10 militants gunned down in separate KP raids

Dawn Report

NORTH WAZIRISTAN / LAKKI MARWAT: At least 10 militants, including a key commander and a bomb maker, were killed in separate security operations in North Waziristan and Lakki Marwat districts, officials claimed on Monday.

In North Waziristan, an ongoing operation by security forces in the Datta Khel area killed eight militants in the mountainous Khursin and Doga Macha regions.

The slain militants were linked to the Hafiz Gul Bahadur and Jaish-i-Mehdi Karwan groups, including a bomb-making expert, sources claimed.

According to sources, some militants are still in hiding, using civilians as human shields to deter strikes on their location.

Separately in Lakki Marwat, security forces killed two militants

in a clash late on Sunday night. A police official said that police and counter-terrorism units encountered terrorists near the Mangala forest during a search and strike operation.

"When the law enforcers reached near the forest, they saw eight to ten terrorists armed with advanced weapons," he said.

The militants fired at police, triggering a half-hour gunfight. Afterward, two terrorists were found dead, while others fled into the dark forest.

The law enforcers seized arms and ammunition and shifted the bodies to the THQ Hospital in Serai Naurang town.

Also in Lakki Marwat, two relatives of a police official were wounded when terrorists attacked his home in the Mir Qalam Pull area.

Head constable Sanaullah said in a preliminary report that his family awoke to dogs barking at

midnight. When his brother, Rafaqatullah, 22, and wife, Rehana Bibi, 40, went outside their rooms, gunfire erupted.

"In the meanwhile, an intense firing started and he immediately took position in the rooftop watch-tower," Sanaullah said.

He saw armed men firing, injuring his brother and wife. He returned fire for twenty minutes, causing the attackers to flee. The injured were taken to a Bannu hospital, and search for the assailants was underway.

Meanwhile, six suspected bandits injured three motorcyclists near Pasani under Serai Gambila police jurisdiction on Sunday night. Victims were riding a motorcycle when the bandits signalled them to stop with a torch. Upon not stopping, the bandits opened fire.

The injured were taken to THQ Hospital in Serai Naurang, and a case was filed against the unidentified attackers.

French PM ousted after no-confidence vote

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President Macron left scrambling to find a successor; country plunged into another political crisis

PARIS: France's parliament on Monday ousted the government of Prime Minister Francois Bayrou after just nine months in office, leaving President Emmanuel Macron scrambling to find a successor and plunging the country into a new political crisis.

Bayrou, who has been in the job for just nine months, had blindsided even his allies by calling a

confidence vote to end a lengthy standoff over his austerity budget, which foresees almost 44 billion euros (\$52 billion) of cost savings to reduce France's debt pile.

Bayrou, the first premier in the history of modern France to be ousted in a confidence vote rather than a no-confidence vote, will submit his resignation on Tuesday morning, according to a person close to him who asked not to be named.

In the vote in the National Assembly, 364 deputies voted that they had no confidence in the government while just 194 gave it their confidence. "In line with article 50 of the constitution, the

prime minister must submit the resignation of his government," said speaker Yael Braun-Pivet.

Bayrou is the sixth prime minister under Macron since his 2017 election but the fifth since 2022. Bayrou's ousting leaves the French head of state with a new domestic headache at a time when he is leading diplomatic efforts on the Ukraine war.

But defending his decision to call the high-risk confidence vote, Bayrou told the National Assembly: "The biggest risk was not to take one, to let things continue without anything changing... and have business as usual." —AFP

‘Punitive laws impede free speech in C’wealth nations’

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CHRI report blames ‘past inaction’ for contributing to serious and persistent challenges to freedom of expression and rule of law

Dawn Report

KARACHI: A report published by the Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (CHRI) found that national laws in many Commonwealth member countries severely impede press freedom and unduly restrict the right to freedom of expression.

A press release stated that the CHRI, the Commonwealth Journalists Association (CJA) and the Commonwealth Lawyers Association (CLA) called on member states to urgently repeal “laws that criminalise legitimate public speech” and take decisive action to protect media

workers and watchdogs from violence and intimidation.

“The report *Who Controls the Narrative? Legal Restrictions on Freedom of Expression in the Commonwealth* finds that criminal provisions for speech offences, including defamation and sedition, as well as violations of national security laws, are arbitrarily applied to intimidate and silence journalists, human rights defenders, and government critics,” the press release read.

“A key objective, the authors argue, must be to decriminalise defamation laws in 41 Commonwealth countries — many of which permit long prison sentences.”

According to the press release, the report is based on analyses of national legal frameworks and draws on testimonies from over 30 senior journalists and 35 lawyers across Africa, Asia, the Americas and the Caribbean, Europe and the Pacific regions.

The report concludes that the Commonwealth’s past inaction has “contributed to the serious and per-

sistent challenges to the protection of freedom of expression and the rule of law in some member countries”.

The report urges the secretariat and member states to act resolutely, together with non-governmental organisations, to ensure observance of the 11-point Commonwealth Principles on Freedom of Expression and the Role of the Media in Good Governance adopted by Heads of Government in Samoa.

“These media principles call on governments to create a safe and enabling environment for media workers, and to review and consider amending unduly restrictive domestic laws that inhibit free speech both online and offline,” the press release read.

According to the press release, the report found that 213 journalists were killed in 19 Commonwealth countries between 2006 and 2023, and in 96 per cent of cases, the perpetrators were not brought to justice, according to Unesco figures.

It also found that 41 Commonwealth countries maintain criminal penalties for defamation; 48 retain laws

related to sedition; and 37 have legislation regarding blasphemy, the press release stated.

“The Commonwealth Ministerial Action Group (CMAG) is urged to fulfil its mandate to address systematic constraints on civil society and the media,” the press release read. “The CMAG should be reformed and supported by a Commonwealth Envoy on Freedom of Expression.”

The CHRI, CJA and CLA urged member states to develop action plans with state and non-state actors to accelerate the repeal of criminal legislation for speech and anti-state offences in line with international best practice.

“Collaborate with civil society and international human rights organisations, including UNESCO, to monitor and support the implementation of the Commonwealth Media Principles,” the three bodies urged, requesting that members prioritise the protection of civil and political rights.

“Too many Commonwealth countries continue to enforce colonial-era

laws that criminalise speech and silence dissent, in clear violation of their international obligations,” Sneh Aurora, Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative director, was quoted as saying.

“The media principles adopted by [the] heads of government in Samoa provide a timely opportunity for member states to take concrete steps — through law reform and institutional safeguards — to protect freedom of expression and align national laws with international human rights standards.”

William Horsley of the CJA said: “The almost complete failure of Commonwealth countries to prosecute and punish those responsible for the killings of over 200 journalists in 20 years is shameful.

“This culture of impunity must be swept away. A genuine Commonwealth engagement to protect the truth-tellers from threats and reprisals would give the organisation a vital new sense of purpose at a time when the concept of truth is under fierce attack.”

Hamas must accept deal, says Trump in 'last warning'

• UN Human Rights chief says he's 'horrified by the open use of genocidal rhetoric' by Israeli officials • Israel's defence minister asks Hamas to 'lay down arms' or 'face annihilation' • Netanyahu tells residents of Gaza City to evacuate; four Israeli soldiers killed

WASHINGTON/JERUSALEM: US President Donald Trump said on Sunday he was issuing a "last warning" to Hamas, saying the Palestinian group must accept a deal to release Israeli prisoners.

"The Israelis have accepted my terms. It is time for Hamas to accept as well. I have warned Hamas about the consequences of not accepting. This is my last warning," Donald Trump said on social media.

"We had some very good discussions. Good things could happen," he told reporters. "I think we're going to have a deal on Gaza very soon."

Meanwhile, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told residents of Gaza City on Monday to evacuate, and the military said four soldiers were killed in the Gaza Strip when an unidentified person "lobbed an explosive device into their tank".

In response to Trump's comments, Hamas said it was ready to "immediately sit at the negotiating table" following "some ideas received from the American side aimed at reaching a ceasefire agreement".

In exchange for a truce, Hamas said it wanted "a clear declaration of the end of the war, a full withdrawal from the Gaza Strip, and the formation of a committee of independent Palestinians to manage the Gaza Strip, which would begin its duties immediately".

Hamas agreed last month to a ceasefire proposal that involved a 60-day truce and staggered prisoner releases.

Israel, however, has demanded that Hamas release all the prisoners at once, disarm itself and relinquish control of Gaza, among other conditions.

In Geneva, United Nations rights chief Volker Turk said he was "horrified by the open use of genocidal rhetoric by senior Israeli officials".

'Face annihilation'

Israel's defence minister warned Hamas on Monday to "lay down your arms" or "face annihilation".

"This is a final warning to Hamas: release the hostages (prisoners) and put down your weapons or Gaza will be destroyed and you will be annihilated," Defence Minister Israel Katz said on X.

The Israeli minister threatened that "today, a massive hurricane will hit the skies of Gaza City", where he said the military was "preparing to expand" operations.

Israel has stepped up operations, levelling high-rise buildings in Gaza City which it has vowed to capture, despite mounting international pressure to stop the bombardment.

'Genocidal rhetoric'

The UN rights chief accused Israeli officials of using overt "genocidal rhetoric" about Gaza and called for decisive international action to "end the carnage".

In a speech to the UN Human Rights Council that was criticised by Israel, Volker Turk said the occupied Palestinian territory was already "a graveyard".

He stressed that "the region is crying out for peace".

Turk accused Israel of inflicting indescribable suffering and wholesale destruction.

"I am horrified by the open use of genocidal rhetoric and the disgraceful dehumanisation of Palestinians by senior Israeli officials."

"Further militarisation, occupation, annexation and oppression will only feed more violence, retribution and terror," Volker Turk warned.

He insisted Israel had "a legal obligation to take the steps ordered by the International Court of Justice to prevent acts of genocide, punish incitement to genocide and ensure enough aid reaches Palestinians in Gaza".

The UN rights chief said the international community was "failing the people of Gaza".

"Where are the decisive steps to prevent genocide," he wondered.

Ravina Shamdasani, the spokeswoman for Volker Turk, said "shocking and dehumanising language" has been used by a number of high-level officials, stressing that "this is not a case of one senior official mouthing off".

Two teens killed in Jenin

The Palestinian health ministry said that the Israeli military killed two teenagers at a refugee camp in Jenin on Monday.

The two victims were named by the ministry as Islam Abdel Aziz Nouh Majarmeh and Muhammad Sari Omar Masqala, both aged 14.

Palestinian official news agency Wafa reported that the two boys were killed after Israeli soldiers "opened fire at a group of civilians who attempted to inspect their houses in the camp and retrieve some of their belongings".—AFP



GAZA CITY: Smoke billows as Israeli bombardment brings down the Al-Ruya Tower, located near tents that shelter displaced Palestinians in the Rimal area. Israel has been warning for weeks of a new assault on the territory's largest city, without issuing a timeline.—AFP